

The
Price
of
Dreams

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Chapter 1

I woke up disoriented, in a strange place, feeling absolutely exhausted. I didn't know what woke me or how long I'd been asleep, but it seemed like I'd been trying to get a decent night's sleep for years. When my life started falling apart, and the specter of homelessness started to loom over me, I never imagined the thing I would miss most would be a good night's sleep.

Not that I ever had an easy time sleeping before. I mean, part of what brought me down was difficulty sleeping. Some of that came from my creative side. When inspiration hit, whether it was a story I was trying to write or a picture I wanted to paint, the creative impulse took hold and didn't let go until I passed out from exhaustion. While I was caught up in it, nothing else mattered. Those were the only moments I ever really felt certain of anything.

Unfortunately, I was not making a living from my art and writing. I had to take whatever odd jobs I could get to pay the bills, and the income was rarely enough to do more. If I could not get a full-time position, I got two or three part time jobs, or I cycled through temp and contract work. At the end of the day, with time taken out for meals, chores, errands, bathing and sleep, there wasn't much left for writing or drawing.

So, occasionally, I sacrificed sleep for art.

More often, I just lay awake battling my personal demons. The truth is, I did not write or draw anywhere near enough to stay good at it. Worse, the demons started to creep into my art and I found myself creating things I didn't want to share with anyone. Okay, I wasn't dreaming up *Fight Club*, but my art became my therapy and the results were way too personal to hang on a wall or publish.

I pushed those thoughts back and shifted my weight, trying to find a comfortable position and discovering that my bed for the night was a couch. It had the generic familiarity all couches get when you've spent a while couch surfing. The space around me was unfamiliar, and I could not get my eyes to focus on anything in the dark. I stopped counting after four walls, concluding that the room was open to a few others.

That seemed like more shelter than I was accustomed to, so I pulled my coat in tighter around myself and closed my eyes. I missed the warmth and weight of a good blanket, but the absence of night's bitter, biting cold was a relief. I had a pretty decent chance of getting back to sleep. My thoughts were starting to disconnect and spin themselves into images when I heard it again, a muted conversation.

For a few moments, the words crashed over me in a formless wash of surf. One voice had a deep, rumbling undercurrent, while the other sang like wind and children dancing in the sunlight across the sand under the distant cry of birds. I couldn't make out the conversation, but the second voice stirred a memory--unusually vivid as memories can be on the verge of unconsciousness.



I'd been walking, lost in thought and oblivious to the fading light when I'd first heard it. I'd glanced up and came to an absolute stop at the sight of her. I'd never seen her before, but I knew every detail by heart. I had spent years in vain, trying to draw her, to paint her, and I could not believe my eyes. I stared, waiting to spot the fatal flaw, expecting the illusion to collapse as I focused on her.

She finished talking to the person she had bumped into and resumed walking, headed away from the store she had just come out of.

I blinked and rubbed my eyes, but my vision did not change. This girl, whoever she was, was real. And, she was walking away. I fell into her wake without even thinking about it. I recognized the surge of energy that kicked in, the sudden pounding of my pulse, and remembered other times when I had chased after a glimpse, full of hope and bound for disappointment. I always looked twice at girls with red hair, but it was never the right red hair, the right face, the right form. I was never sure what I was looking for, only that I would recognize it when I saw it.

Now that I'd seen it, I felt torn between awe and agony.

It wasn't really necessary to think it through, as I followed. The first time I'd felt this attraction, I thought it was love at first sight. I stumbled into the predictable fiasco, making an absolute idiot of myself and embarrassing the hell out of the poor girl--or completely freaking her out. Probably both.

I learned something from it, though. I didn't find that first girl any more attractive than other girls I'd seen. I was just caught off guard by her resemblance to someone who was intensely and inexplicably imprinted on my brain. I never noticed it before, but I had always measured people against that image, like an archetype or an ideal.

I looked for her the way a person looks for a lost loved one.

It sort of made sense. I was 5 years old when I was adopted, and I lost touch with everyone I knew in the process. I had no idea who this girl was, but she clearly represented someone very important to me, someone torn away from me who I remained connected to at an unconscious level.

It's as good a theory as any. All I really knew was that I had this girl on the brain. Jung would call her my Anima. I tended to think of her as my Muse. A very frustrating muse I was never able to see clearly enough to draw or paint, or even capture in writing. She was kind of like the sun, shedding light and warmth on everything around her, but I couldn't look directly at her without going blind.

Not the version of her that lived in my head, anyway.

I knew the girl I was following could not possibly her, but she was a perfect match for the template in my head. She was about five inches shorter than me, but tall for a girl. Slender, but obviously athletic--she was more of a dancer than a gymnast, and probably a swimmer. Her movements had a quiet grace, a confident poise. There was something slightly feline in her features. A heart shaped face, straight nose, generous mouth and eyes like a storm on the ocean. Her dark red hair was full and long, with rogue curls rippling free from flowing waves.

A lot to take in at a glance, and a glance could never be enough--I was not the only one on that street inclined to stare at her.

Apart from wanting to get a better look at her, I had no idea what to do if I caught up to her. I was living rough and looked like it. I'd scare the crap out of her if I tried to approach her, and even if I didn't, what could I say--"I need to look at you"? Creepy enough, but the truth was, I wanted to study her for hours. Draw her. Paint her. Capture her image so I could never forget it. I was an artist, but if I said so, she'd probably think it was a pick-up line.

I was pretty sure I had a sketch book and a few pencils in my book bag, so maybe if she stopped somewhere for a while, I could perch somewhere nearby and do some random sketching. Provide a little evidence of my trade before trying to make contact.

Wow. That sounded stalker-creepy just thinking it to myself. I know it comes from being a writer. Planning scenes out comes as naturally to me as breathing. The problem is, that kind of scenario works in a story because the characters are generally innocent of intent--or they're bad guys.

I don't think about my appearance much, but I could see my reflection in every window we passed: Tall, dark and not particularly handsome. Dressed in black; worn leather shoes, denim jeans, t-shirt and leather jacket, with a black bag at my hip. Oval face, worn features--pretty sinister looking in the early evening light--with long, fine dark hair pulled back into a thin pony-tail.

Some girls find me attractive, but if I was a girl, I think I'd find me kind of frightening.

While I was fretting about that, I realized I was catching up with her. She had stopped several times to talk to people, and before I could even wonder what she was up to, one of the people in the group she was talking to tapped her on the shoulder and pointed directly at me.

I resisted the urge to look behind me as she turned in my direction. She gave me a quick look, down to my shoes and up again to meet my eyes--which had to be wide with disbelief. I stopped in my tracks and stared back, as she took inventory of my appearance. Any doubts I had about her appearance fled, along with my wits, as she seemed to run through a mental checklist.

I didn't know how I knew. The body language was as subtle as it gets, but I knew the process from the inside out. She'd never seen me before, but she knew exactly what she was looking for. Part of me thought that made perfect sense, but the rational part was trying to seize up in denial. While I stood, brain locked, she nodded and excused herself from the group of strangers she'd been talking to.

She shook her head as she approached me. Coming to a stop, she gave me a final appraisal and announced casually, "You look like shit. That threw me for a moment."

The gears in my head slipped and words spilled out. "This is where I'm supposed to wake up."

Her eyes locked on mine, and she smiled. "You look like you're about to pass out, actually."

To my complete mortification, that's exactly what I did.



I blinked my eyes and rubbed my face, dread certainty settling in as I came fully awake. I'd had dreams like this before. Sometimes it was just a glimpse in the kaleidoscope of fantasy and memory that stews in my sleep. Sometimes it seemed as real to me as anything I'd ever known. Sometimes more real. The hard part was always waking up and having it all slip away.

Before that rationalization could seat me firmly back in line with harsh reality, a voice intruded. Her voice. "Have you finally gotten around to waking up?" she asked, stepping out of the shadows of an adjoining room and into the fall of light from a window somewhere above me--in the wall to the right of the couch, actually.

"I don't know," I confessed, certain I should feel even more disoriented, but mostly clinging to the hope that returning consciousness usually crushed. "I could just be dreaming I'm awake. I should be asking where I am, but all that really matters is that you're here. If I am dreaming, I hope I don't wake up."

"Works for me," she replied, "as long as you don't pass out again."

I nodded; then shook my head. "I can't believe I did that. I don't think that's ever happened to me before." I slipped my legs off the couch and sat up. The closest experience I could think of was nodding off after a big meal—or a few days without sleep. In those cases, I'd feel my head going into a fog and could try to fight off sleep. Before I blacked out, I felt like my brain was in overdrive, seeing the world with unnatural clarity and then: snap; out go the lights.

"Sorry about that. I didn't plan to catch you off guard like that. You were harder to find than I expected," she explained, sliding gracefully into a chair across from me.

I couldn't help smiling. "I never expected to find you at all." I took a deep breath and sighed. "You're not surprised by that," I observed, the intuitive part of me screaming about the implications my rational mind still refused to consider. "I still don't know why I was looking, and it never really occurred to me you'd come searching for me."

She shrugged. "I'm just sorry it took so long. You're older than I was expecting. You weren't supposed to be homeless."

"I feel the same, if it makes any difference," I tried to joke. I got the ghost of a smile in reply, but then she fell silent, waiting. I could have asked why she was looking for me, but I was afraid I already knew. I'd spent a long time thinking about the impossible, looking at it from the outside. It should have felt more confusing to look at it from the inside, and in many ways it was. Questions were flooding through me, but I couldn't bring myself to ask any of them, because I felt like I already knew all the answers.

It was scaring the crap out of me.

She looked calm. Completely confident in herself, her expression touched with sympathy and wry amusement. She knew I was on the verge of freaking out. "I'd introduce myself, but you know me better than I do, so the real question--the one that you're trying like crazy not to ask--is, what am I doing here?"

I opened my mouth, but nothing would come out.

She laughed, and then she sighed. "It's okay. I freaked out pretty bad when was reading the books for the first time."

"Books?" It was not the most articulate question I ever asked, but it squeaked out past the collision of other questions that leapt to mind.

"Your books," she clarified with a piercing glare. "The books about me. The books you don't seem to have written yet. That's why I was looking for you."

Just like that, all the questions went silent. I didn't need them. I could not deny that, impossible as it seemed, I probably did have all the answers. I knew it, because I knew the exact scene she was talking about. I'd thought about it for years, trying to figure out how to write it.

It was a simple premise, and one that seemed brilliant every time I looked at it. In the fantasy story I wrestled with endlessly on my word processor, my protagonist, an embodiment of my muse, stumbled across a collection of books from another world: Books that focused on her and her adventures. It was kind of my own take on Heinlein's World-As-Myth paradigm.

If I'd been able to write my stories, and managed to get them published, I would have thought someone was trying to punk me. As she pointed out, however, I didn't write them. How could someone punk me with something that only existed in my head?

I stood up, skirted the coffee table between us, and knelt beside her chair. She watched as I put a hand on her knee. Under a layer of synthetic-fiber material that, to the best of my knowledge, existed only in fiction, her knee felt warm and solid.

"I've never been prone to vivid hallucinations. Some drugs really mess with my senses, but my mind has never played a trick like this on me," I commented, trying to wrap my head around what was happening.

She gave a harsh laugh, "This is just a taste of what I went through, reading those books."

I nodded. The books may not have gotten finished, or published, but I spent decades trying to write them--thinking every scene through over and over, trying to get them right. "I've got an idea. I never got that part of the story perfect, so I can only guess what you really went through. Some versions were pretty ugly," I admitted.

She stared at me for a moment. Something passed behind her eyes, washing out a subtle tension I had not noticed until it was gone. "I think I finally get it. Part of it, at least," she said, to herself, I assumed.

"If any of this makes sense to you, you're way ahead of me," I told her. I returned to the couch, and kicked my feet up on the coffee table.

"There's still some paradox involved, but not the kind I was most afraid of," she said, pulling her feet up under herself, as she shifted into a more comfortable position on the chair. "For a while, I was afraid that finding you would be like meeting my maker. I'm sorry, but, well" she made a broad gesture in clear reference to my appearance, "you're not what I picture when I think of the Goddess."

I looked down at myself and had to smirk. "You would not be alone in that!"

She screwed up her nose and gave me a lopsided smile, and we both burst out laughing. When I got my breath back, I said, "I can almost imagine how this is possible, you being here, me being able to write about you, if I slip into writer mode. I don't know if I could explain it, and it's just not possible at all in the world I live in. But it's happening. You're here. How?"

She sighed heavily, "Damn. I was hoping you'd be able to tell me. But, if you haven't finished the story, then I guess you don't know as much as I expected. I was hoping you were the key to getting back home. Now, I'm thinking this is how the paradox gets resolved."

I was pretty sure I could follow that, but it couldn't hurt to be sure. "You think you're here because I didn't write the books?"

She cocked her head to the side in thought, gnawing on her lower lip for a moment, before shrugging and giving me a nod. "You seem to already be tuned in to me somehow, but there's some kind of interference. You said there are different versions of what happens to me. The story I read was accurate, but the story you're writing isn't finished. Now that I am here, I can help you finish the story. Maybe, in the process, we can figure out how I get home."

I took a moment to digest that. I had to. I've got a pretty open mind, and honestly, I wished for most of my life that the people and places in the best sci-fi and fantasy novels were real. I'm sure I'm not alone in feeling that way. Nothing in my experience--short of dreams--prepared me to confront the possibility that they were. In dreams, you can take the impossible in stride. Stop to confront it--try to grasp it rationally--and you just wake yourself up.

So, I tried to take it slow. "You seem real. God knows, I want you to be real. So, it follows that your home is real; all those things I struggled to write about are real: Gods, angels, demons, dragons, magic, and all of that. It's all real."

"I don't think 'real' is the right word," she said, shaking her head. "Not the way you mean it. It's more accurate to say those things are true. They exist independent of the world you live in, and the people in your world don't really know how to engage something like that. Not even your own souls. When you're trapped in the box, it doesn't matter what tools lie outside the box."

"And the box is reality?" I asked.

"No. To put it very simply, the box is life," she said, holding up a hand before I could interrupt. "The trap is thinking reality exists only inside the box; that there is nothing outside the box to engage in. The trap is when the box is your only reality; when you deny anything outside the limits of the box."

I considered that for a moment, before venturing, "So, it's not accurate to say all the things I know of from your world are all real, but it would be right to say that those are all things that have their own reality?"

She raised her eyebrows and gave a little nod. "That would work."

Chapter 2

Under normal circumstances, I'd be inclined to explore the premise and implications of actual, discrete realities, but when the embodiment of your imagination drags your unconscious ass off the street to discuss your failure to write her story, well, we're obviously not talking about a normal circumstance. She'd already admitted she did not have an explanation for how she got here, so I considered the next question.

The story. Her story. If anyone should know it, it was her. If anything should be impossible, it would be me knowing her story the way I did. At least, that would normally be the case with the life story of someone you met on the street. Again, normal did not quite apply to this situation. Without a single attempt to establish the details of her story, we'd already referred to it the way two old acquaintances addressed a shared experience.

On the other hand, there was one thing the story could not account for.

"So, how is it that you know me?" I asked, finally scratching at the itch that started bothering me from the moment she first spoke to me. "I always intended to publish under a pseudonym--a pen name."

"Oh, you did," she admitted, giving me an irritated look. "Fortunately, the books I found about me were just a subset of the collection of books written about you." Her irritation evolved into amused satisfaction at my shock. Before I recovered, she went on, "But the truth is, I was dreaming about you for a long time before I got access to that library."

I blinked. A smug voice in the back of my head told me I should have known, but had chosen not to. Rather than pursue that thought, I focused on her. "You dreamed about me?"

"Um," she looked off to the side and cleared her throat. "It was more like, I had nightmares about you." Her eyes turned back to me. "Nightmares about being you."

My mouth went dry and my throat suddenly tried to close up. I dragged my feet off the coffee table and planted them on the floor, leaning forward to brace my elbows on my knees. I knew the story. I knew she had always been plagued by nightmares, but... "I thought your nightmares were about the massacre--the night your... mother died."

She looked away again, and closed her eyes; concealing the stab of an old wound. Her reply was a bit tight, "That's where they often start--and end. In the middle, they go down stranger, darker paths that seem to go on forever and I get so lost... I can barely remember who I am."

My gut clenched. "And that's when you dream of being me?"

She hesitated before nodding.

I pushed up and stalked away in a sudden fury of conflicting emotion. There was nowhere to go. No way I wanted to walk away from her. I didn't even really see anything but her, and yet I felt like I was riding a rocket out of the atmosphere. I didn't get more than a few steps before I stopped, and let the thunder roll through me.

This is what mountains feel like in that terrifying moment they remember they are volcanoes--in the brief passion of exploding; shattering and dissolving into choking clouds of ash. When they turn inside out, revealing their hollow shells and molten cores.

"It's not the same," I breathed, hands clenching into fists as if I could keep from flying away if I just held on to myself tight enough. "I dream about you, sometimes. Sometimes, for an instant, I'm someone like you. I've never really dreamed of being you," I declared in a hollow, aching voice.

"Not when you're asleep," she corrected softly. Her hand grasped me by the shoulder and with firm but gentle strength she turned me to face her; met me eye to eye. "But you dream about me almost every moment you're awake. I am always on your mind, and that's why it's such a nightmare to be you."

The emotion that thrust me to my feet was spent, and for one endless instant the whole universe stood silent and still. Then I was in free fall. Her hands slid down my arms, gently closing about my fists. With that same firm, feather-light touch, she brought our hands up into our line of sight.

I already knew this metaphor. I used it to describe what I call the point paradox. When you hold on to nothing, you grasp yourself. It's the fundamental existential paradox. "A story isn't the words on a page. Words are just the ashes of a fire that burns only in the mind. My story, burning in your mind; you, consciously unleashing your imagination; you dream of being me when you're wide awake," she asserted passionately.

What could I say? A person could define the creative process in other terms, but her description was weirdly accurate and essentially true. The tricky part, as always in the case of a truth, was knowing what it actually meant. I pulled my hands free and ran my palms over my face, covering my eyes. The mask I wear is one I cannot take off, but she managed to strip it away almost effortlessly, shattering the lie that lets me function as a human being.

"I guess that's the problem," I confessed after a moment, from behind the shelter of my hands. "I had a dream instead of a life. It was a good dream; too good, really. For all the pain and horror, and all the paradoxes, too good to be true. A great story, but..." I took a deep breath and sighed, dropping my hands. "I was looking for a way to survive, and it was too strange and complicated a story to find a marketable audience."

She regarded me thoughtfully for a moment. "I think I understand," she finally said, drifting toward an end table and turning on a lamp. As the light spilled into the room, she gestured at the lamp's twin on the matching table at the other end of the couch. She continued speaking as I lit the other light. "I've passed through your life like a leaf in a hurricane. I saw more than was in the books, but I have to guess at the proper sequence."

I crossed my arms and looked down. "If I'd had any balance in my life, I might have been able to finish writing and publish. I don't know if I'd have gotten the story right, though. I know what you mean by 'leaf in a hurricane'; I've always been able to glimpse the pieces, and I have a good grasp of the overall picture, but I was never able to figure out how it all fits together," I admitted.

I looked around, part of my mind trying to place myself in an unfamiliar environment, wondering whose home we were in. Where was the guy she'd been speaking to when I woke up? What compelled a stranger to take a strange couple into his home? It was a blank that would have needed an answer if I was writing this scenario. Actually, it was a blank I'd need to fill in somehow, now that I'd fallen into the story I was supposed to write.

Oh, nice stumbling block there. "How the hell am I going to write the story now?" I found myself complaining aloud.

That made her laugh, and hearing it made me want to cry. I know, that's odd, but it's a symptom of my life. My own laughter never felt or sounded right to me. I never laughed the same way twice. Something pegs my humor meter, and some weird, random sound came out of me. Sometimes it was outright creepy.

When she laughed, it sounded right--even laced with painful understanding of my complaint. She ended with a deep breath and a sigh, saying, "I don't know much about writing, but I assume you just write. Put the ideas down as they come to you; when you run out of ideas, take what you've got and try to put them in order. I'm guessing you've tried that, though."

I gave her an exasperated look. "We are talking about your life here, right?"

She opened her mouth, thought about it for a second, then nodded with another sigh. "You're right. It couldn't possibly be that easy. If I hadn't lived it--if I'd tried to imagine it back when my life was reasonably normal--I wouldn't think it was possible to even dream it," she confessed.

Under my breath, I muttered, "I didn't think it was possible to even read it."

She looked at me and frowned. Oops. Guess she heard that--as she quickly confirmed, "I read it. Apart from the fact that I quickly figured out it was impossibly like my life--not so great for my sanity right then--it was a pretty gripping story."

My brows furrowed. "'Like' your life? I thought you said it was accurate?" I challenged.

The look she returned was mockingly skeptical. "Do you have any idea how weird it is to see your world through the lens of an alien language and culture?" she retorted, arms crossed and hip cocked for emphasis.

I rolled my eyes and sighed, half exasperated, half relieved. "I know how hard it is to capture--and by that I mean, fake--the language and culture of a world I was pretty sure existed only in my imagination. At least now I know I don't have to go to all that extra work."

She shook her head in mild disbelief and shrugged. "From my side, it seemed like someone had gone to a lot of extra work to disguise my biography. I've met a few gods who would have gone to the trouble just to mess with my head." She looked at me, scanned the room around us, and returned her eyes to mine. "That could apply even to this," she amended, in clear reference to our situation.

"Anyway," she returned to the point, "the events and situations, the essence of my thoughts and feelings all came through. Not my story the way I might write it, but the way someone with their own perspective, looking through me, would write it. It was that, more than the books about me or you, that convinced me you were out here."

I tucked my head down. I couldn't help it, really. I got an odd feeling, thinking about that conundrum. As a writer, the sky is the limit. It's fun to play with the notion of gods; people who

personified power, shaping reality the way a writer shapes a story. It was amusing to think you could find the lives of ordinary people on the shelves of their libraries.

Confronting it as a possible reality, with only one degree of separation, ought to have seemed frightening--at the very least, deeply disturbing. To me, right then, it just seemed preposterous. My life didn't make a good story. It hardly qualified as a life. She had it characterized much better as a nightmare. It was tainted by one mundane and ugly paradox.

Painful, but tame and boring compared to a life like hers.



I'm not even sure how the idea came to me, originally. I think I'd been sketching an outline of her life, and it sort of came up after her death--which troubled me, but given where her adventures had taken her, dying wasn't enough to end her adventures. I could see her coming back to life somewhere down the road, but I knew the trip to the library would send her down another path first.

I never felt comfortable about exploring that path. It hurt to imagine a scene like this, writing it out but not living it. That was the reality I expected to face; not this. In a way, I guess I believed, deep down, that the story had its own reality, and I wanted to preserve that faith. How could I knowingly write myself into the story without at least that part glaring back at me as pure fiction?

I'd lied to myself enough up to that point. I didn't have the stomach to do it again, even if that was what the story called for. I guess that was when I started to lose the thread of the story, trying to change it to suit a broader audience. When my demons began to work their way into the fabric of the story. With a deep sigh, I confessed, "That's where I fell prey to doubt."

She just nodded, as if she was expecting me to say that. Well, if I was her nightmare, I suppose she would. Then she said something that proved how well she knew me. "That's also pretty much where you stopped lying to yourself. Isn't it?"

I crossed my arms, head still bowed--almost masking my slow, timid nod--as I confirmed, "Yeah. That's where my life really started to fall apart. And, where the story started to take on a different meaning for me." I forced myself to look up, and say what I had to say to her face, "I began to see my inspiration in a different way, and question all the things that brought you to mind and unlocked your story.

"It didn't kill the story for me, but it expanded the paradox," I explained, holding myself tightly. "I started to get a better understanding of how a time paradox works, and of course, I kept getting lost trying to follow the path, searching for the way in and out--knowing how it ends while growing less and less certain about the beginning."

By refusing to consider direct involvement in the story on my part, I realized that I might have imposed myself on the story in a far more disruptive way. I was still debating how to bring that concern up when she broke the silence.

"The beginning..." she murmured softly, thoughtfully. "We never remember the beginning," she continued, pursuing a notion my words kicked loose in her skull. "We pretend not to know why--but then that is one of our favorite tricks, isn't it?" she glanced up at me, smiling at my confused silence.

With her arms crossed she began to drift about the room, examining objects while continuing this strange interlocution. "We pretend not to know many things. We can even pretend not to know the truth. The horrible truth. But the beginning?" she paused and met my eye in the mirror across the room from the couch. "Well there is an explanation for that one. We never remember the beginning because there never was a beginning. That's one of those horrible parts of the truth we choose to miss."

"What do you mean?" I asked. Her choice of words--the horrible truth--bothered me inexplicably. My own musing forgotten for the moment, I wanted to argue with her; as a writer, I wanted to point out the fact that there are many beginnings and how easy it is to remember most of them.

The urge to argue was so strong that I felt suspicious of it. It might have been an appropriate impulse for one of the philosophic, speculative debates I used to get into with my old friends at the pub, but the honest part of me knew I was trying to keep from asking "What horrible truth?" aloud.

She turned to face me, and the look she gave me made me feel like I asked the wrong question. I thought she was waiting for me to rephrase my query, but, before I could think of the right question to ask, she reprimanded, "You know what I mean."

For a moment I didn't know if she was answering the question I asked or the question I kept to myself. Or were they the same thing?

"We never remember the beginning," she went on, not even sparing me a second look, "until the very end; because there is no end either. How can there be when at either moment you're right in the middle of it? None of which makes sense, of course, until you risk looking at the truth. I wish I could tell you that truth. Honestly."

"Why couldn't you?" I prompted, hoping for something to define where this conversation was heading.

She smiled to herself. A rather frightening smile. "And pour water into a full glass?" She laughed. It was still a mesmerizing sound. "The truth is already there. You already understand it on some level. It

just doesn't fit into your perspective; you don't know how to explain it to yourself. It's like being in a conversation and thinking about what you want to say when you should just be listening."

She wasn't looking at me. I doubt she was looking at anything in particular. It struck me suddenly that she was holding herself poised to listen. On sheer reflex, I tuned into the background as well, and she spoke again, "So, telling you the truth... the trick is just getting you to listen."

"What?" I blurted, startled by the fact that she had basically done just that; tricking me into listening.

"We never remember the beginning," she said quietly, precisely as she had before. I looked at her with a frown, but she carried on without regarding it. "We pretend not to know why--but then that is one of our favorite tricks, isn't it? We pretend not to know many things. We can even pretend not to know the truth. The horrible truth.

"But the truth?" she held that in the air a moment, and looked at me pointedly. She held up her hands for emphasis.

Realizing that the question was not rhetorical, I nodded.

"The truth is a constant. It doesn't need to repeat itself," she declared. As she went on, she measured out her words, "I can remember the beginning."



Before I could ask the beginning of what she cut me off with a gesture, and resumed the pose of listening. This caused my agitation to grow. I have never considered myself an insensitive person. Indeed, there were times I felt proud of my sensitivity to the subtlest of cues.

As a child I was so sensitive that there were moments when I seemed to get caught up in the thoughts and feelings of the people around me. I don't know where that notion could have come from, but my best guess has been that I could read the state of a person's mind so well from their body language that I would experience sympathetic thoughts and feelings.

What am I driving at? Well, at that moment, her gesture struck me so suddenly she might have just as well screamed "Listen!" at the top of her lungs.

That shock subsided quickly, but I could not shake the feeling that she was communicating--deliberately--on many levels, verbal and non-verbal. I brought my mind into focus and met her eye.

Without words, her body resonating with the charge of an epiphany, she managed to express her awareness of my realization. My eyes widened and she nodded with the faintest smile. The clearest

The Price of Dreams

thought chimed in my head, ~Ears hear, but the mind listens... the mind listens with every sense and it becomes a sense.~

~Can you read my mind?~

I was nodding my head before I even thought to question the origin of the thought. My mind fell still, the silence ringing with heightened awareness. I didn't have to question what beginning she was talking about, because suddenly it was obvious what beginning people were oblivious to. The moment we become self-aware.

She smiled broadly at me and nodded assertively. Without further distractions she resumed speaking.

Chapter 3

Her attention seemed to withdraw from the world into some all consuming inner vision. I don't know if it was the little mind trick she'd just pulled on me, or if it was the fact that I've had the story on my mind for decades, but at that moment, it took little effort to tune into it with her.

"It seems sort of odd to call it the beginning, because I can remember what led up to that moment..." she paused, eyes dancing blindly around the room as she focused on a memory. "After all, I sort of came back to it in the end"

In a flash, I picked out the point in the story best fitting that statement. I frowned. Over the years, I'd discovered that there were an endless number of ways that moment was set up and played out. A genuine quantum paradox. "Sometimes, the paradox seems to work out that way, but I have trouble holding onto the thread," I noted softly, thinking rapidly through the nesting loops of paradox.

I could take a long time to deliberate on the potential and probability or plausibility of it without scratching the surface of its possibility. As far as the story goes, though, it happens--even if what happens is inexplicable. One way or another, she stepped outside the box and found her way back to where she made the choice to exist.

Everything else seems to result as a consequence. I sighed, "Even when I sure I have it clear in my mind, I'm not sure I can write it down in a way that would make sense to most people."

"But you know what I am talking about?" she tested.

I shrugged. "I suppose we could say, you sort of saw yourself coming. It's not the first paradox I encountered in your story, but it's obviously the key." I chuckled, wishing I could be more specific. "It sort of takes the whole story to establish the concept of the paradox it depends on."

"At the start, you were oblivious to yourself; that is, not conscious of yourself independent from what you were aware of. You were in perfect phase with a high order, utterly selfless consciousness--a holographic mind. Brahman, in Hinduism. That much must be true if you possess memories predating yourself."

She nodded.

"At the end--or at least after what has to be considered your physical death--you didn't just cease to exist. In simple terms, you dreamed," I clarified, to another nod. "Ignoring for the moment that there's more than one possible path leading back, you returned to the threshold of consciousness; fully-resolved in spirit. There on the edge of eternity, on the verge of absolution..."

I paused, shaking my head, "I'm sorry, the only simple way I can say it is, you confronted the point paradox. That wouldn't mean anything to most people."

She waved it off, "No, it's okay. You explain it in the books. So, yeah, we're on the same page, so to speak."

"I have to take your word for it. It still confuses the hell out of me," I drawled, starting to pace off my frustration. "It seems like every time I get one thread nailed down, the others start to pop loose and I go through another round of chasing everything down."

I stopped between the chairs, on the opposite side of the coffee table from the couch, and turned back to her. "At the moment, I think this lines up with the dragon dream."

"On a physical timeline, yeah," she confirmed, before adding, "On a cognitive timeline, it was the moment I saw my reflection in the absolute; the instant I glanced away from eternity. I stepped into the open and found myself alone, at the center of it all, the eyes of the infinite on me," she whispered.

In the story, this is where the girl confronted the naked goddess--oblivious to her apotheosis. This was the scene in which she conceived of herself and set the whole paradox in motion. In a more general sense, this was a moment when potential and possibility trumped probability and plausibility. "This is where the Goddess tells you you're not going to die. That you're just on the verge of waking up."

She nodded tentatively, head tilted back in a heavenward gaze. "At the time, I managed to convince myself the whole thing was just a dream. A metaphor for confronting my higher self, especially

since I seemed to experience both sides of it. You know, just me looking at who I was, from a completely objective perspective, and concluding that I was worth saving--even if it meant saving myself.

"On the other hand, it actually was a dream; a glimpse of a possibility. A temptation. I remember that I could have turned away. In hindsight, that would have prevented so much suffering. I could have denied myself, simply done nothing; but once I acted there was nothing I could do to stop the paradox. Because at that moment I changed..."

"I want to say that it was indescribable, but what happened to me--the part of me that had just awakened--was so vivid, so utterly real that reality feels fragile by comparison." She writhed against the limits of the words; a movement at once seductive, sensual and distressed.

I felt apprehensive, unable to avoid thinking of how long she'd been the focus of my attention or how the story exposed her to a potential multitude. I watched her shrug off the unfathomable weight of manifold judgment, and retreat from the memory.

"It sounds simple, but it gets too complicated to explain," she proclaimed, in a remote, contemplative tone. "It's not so much a before and after, but a single event played out from either side. The present divided by apprehension, flickering at the edges of your vision; seen, but not what you were really looking at."

"In the story," I interrupted, pursuing an insight aloud, "you did wake up. Surprised to be alive, you convinced yourself it had to be a dream, along with the events that led up to it. The consequences kept confronting you, but you don't seem to recognize what they mean until there's no other option."

She winced. "Oh, I had my suspicions, but, well it was crazy. I was raised to worship the Goddess. I had enough trouble with being one of those people who believed the Goddess talked to her. Not that I could deny that part," she growled, slanting a glare at me. "Not once I figured out how I got pregnant!"

"And technically a virgin again, after your resurrection," I interjected, trying not to laugh as her glare sharpened. "It does explain what she meant, when she said she couldn't live without you. I couldn't tell exactly when you figured out who your daughter would become, but I'm guessing that's when you came to grips with the paradox and reconsidered what happened the day you died."

"Well, I hit a point where I couldn't deny that I'd become my own mother," she grumbled, with a lingering tone of disbelief. "I got hung up on the fact that I watched my mother die when I was seven years old. Not for fear of dying. I'd gotten over that before."

"The problem was, even if she was really me, and I was really the Goddess," she rolled her eyes and shook her head at the absurdity, "she was still a little girl who needed her mother. I hated knowing I

had to abandon her or risk collapsing the paradox. I just had to trust that what had been would be again, and take responsibility for the world I set in motion."



She stood proud and strong, but I could sense the underlying pain and anguish--the lingering scars of doubt and denial. I reached out and pulled her close, holding her in silence for several long breaths. After a moment, she relaxed and returned my embrace. I rested my cheek on top of her head and murmured, "It may not have occurred to you then, but you have to admit, a paradox does provide a certain amount of protection."

She laughed and squeezed me, arguing, "Why? Because the whole world could collapse in on itself if I die at the wrong time? I spent enough time in the shattered realms to know that's only partially true. The paradox only requires one viable path. This is the only version of me I'm certain makes it this far."

I nodded in grim acknowledgment and pulled back to look at her, "That's all any of us can ever say." She stepped back, nodding, and disengaging with a final squeeze of my hands. I cleared my throat and prompted, "In any case, you eventually accepted the truth. Eventually, you let yourself see things from the beginning."

"Eventually. It was easier to remember than I expected; just hard to accept. Before, the only sense I had of this..." she gestured at herself, and me, before sweeping her arm out to include the world around us. I felt reasonably confident she meant life. "...was vague. A dance of light and shadow, the suggestion of measurable complexity, a distraction tuned out in my preoccupation with everything else."

She zoned out again, her words stretching across the vastness of time. "I remember omniscience; effortless comprehension of everything everywhere. On that scale, I barely noticed her approaching the threshold; but for some reason, I had to look. Such a tiny spark; a mote in the eye of God. I knew instinctively that I understood it, even before I identified it. It came to me like a sensation. Unfolding and embracing me. Growing in detail, unraveling possibilities before my awakening curiosity.

"With growing delight I embraced this wondrous image, a dream promising to fulfill all I could hope to be. It tested everything I could understand. It revealed the others to me, and, on some level, I finally understood who the others were. I only had to look past myself to know them as well as I knew myself. And then I knew something was wrong. And I knew it was too late!" she declared, falling silent and hanging her head.

"I saw who I could be, but in the same instant I saw my death. It was the price of that dream, the cost of every life, but that death in particular was a sudden, rude awakening!" she clenched her fist and eyes tightly; caught up in the pain of this memory.

It was all I could do not to interrupt. I had to resist the disturbing notion that I was listening to some kind of dramatic performance piece rather than an experience from her life. Her body vibrated in frustration; the agitation of a person who simply cannot find words to express an idea or a feeling.

"To become so sharply aware of myself and understand in the same moment that I knew nothing of myself..." she trailed off helplessly, abandoning her tension. She rested her fingertips against her temples as she went on, "I don't know if words could ever express what went on in my mind. All I can say is, my first memory is a moment of self conception. Translated, I thought: This is me."

She paused and turned to look at me directly. It was like she stepped back into reality for a moment to comment, "You remember your first thought, because you are your first thought. That is the secret. At first you are incapable of thought. You look at the world passively for eternity, then suddenly you realize you are there.

"You have defined yourself apart from the world, so naturally you begin to try to define the world. You try to fill the void; you begin to think. Analyze." She shuddered, "Unless you are conceived in doubt.

"God help those who begin with the thought: this is not me. How powerless that must make you feel. To recognize the world but fail to recognize yourself..." She trailed off and became distant again. She either did not notice my wince, or she politely ignored it. I didn't begin with that thought, but I've certainly lived with it for most of my life.

"Then," she resumed, as if she had not interrupted herself, "I turned and really looked at the others. I can remember their experience of that time as well as my own because we were countless souls with one mind. I was only aware of them as a multitude because we were spread out everywhere in spite of not actually being anywhere. They all knew exactly what I knew, but no one else knew what I meant.

"The implications of my choice were explicit, but it was my choice exclusively," she explained, leveling her hands before her as she weighed the options. "Will I? Or, won't I?"

She took a deep breath, and grit her teeth. "As who I am now, I can almost explain it. I acted on impulse. I didn't have to think. I took advantage of my position; harnessed my understanding of everything and committed myself to being this. I knew the cost, but my decision was made. In practical terms, our paths crossed for an instant before carrying us off on different axes of eternity.

"The person I am now woke up with powers I can barely comprehend, but that other me..." she sighed heavily, "I was screwed, and I didn't even know it. I'd stepped out of alignment, and while I had infinite knowledge--and absolute power at my disposal--I had no experience being me. The mind I emerged with was too vast for my soul. I was alone inside it and I lost sight of myself."

"More demon than goddess," I mused softly, finding my way back to the couch and settling down. "I was afraid that would be the case."

"Two sides of a coin, really," she corrected gently. "In the time that followed, I was always the naked goddess, unable to restrain the demon I set loose. My soul sustained it, but there wasn't much to me. While I was lost inside it--right in its blind spot--it preyed on other souls searching creation for me."

"So, the long axis of the paradox has the same origin," I mused thoughtfully, half-congratulating myself for having guessed at it almost from the beginning. That is, from the earliest days of my struggle with the story. "Unfortunate," I noted sourly, remembering the trouble it caused with the story. "A story that hinges too much on its protagonist will turn off a lot of readers."

"I know. It suggests a lack of imagination on the part of the writer, and makes a story feel contrived, but," she shrugged, "I kind of did create a world for myself. Then others came along and made it their own, as well. It started with the souls the demon preyed upon, trapped together in a nightmare that took on a reality of its own as they learned to share the dream."



I rubbed my neck and rolled my head around, trying to relieve some of the tension from this encounter. On one hand, talking with her about the story was a bit like working with a co-writer, someone I'd spent a lot of time developing ideas with. On the other, I just could not forget that I'd never laid eyes on her before that night. "Please tell me this is as weird for you as it is for me," I begged.

She held out her hands and dropped them in resignation. "I'm pretty used to weird, but yeah, this is a strain. I can't help questioning my sanity, even though I know all of this as well as I know anything," she said, looking uncomfortable. "I can't deny what I've experienced, but am I right about what it means? I ask myself that almost every step along the way."

"I wonder if I am truly any different from anyone else. Do I really remember the beginning or was it nothing more than a dream?" she shook her head and flipped her hand over. "Do I see the beginning so clearly now because I really am coming up on the end this time?" she stopped abruptly, startled by her own words. Suddenly her story seemed forgotten, and she visibly began to reconsider what she had begun.

Smoothly, swiftly she swept over beside me and sat on the couch facing me. "Is that why I found you hidden here among those who are aware of the absolute the way they are aware of the truth? Fearfully unexamined?" she asked me, showing an honest need for an answer, saying something unspeakable to me in the asking. My soul ached at her next question. "Do I really need you to write this... or did some god trick me into seeking you out for something else?"

With someone else, I could have come up with an answer, or the question would have been rhetorical. I recalled the start of our conversation, her explanation for seeking me out and how the story she read was filtered through me. That did not literally mean I had to write it. If she knew me well enough, she could write her own story from my perspective--with far less trouble.

If I used the "too good to be true" rule of prediction, it was more than I could hope for to be able to work with her as closely as we would have to in order to complete the story. She was literally the woman of my dreams. Her presence might simplify the writing of the story, but it complicated my life beyond the scope of my imagination. I was surprised I hadn't already cracked.

I was balanced on a photon, holding myself at bay with the absolute terror of pure hope. More than ever, I looked upon the task of writing her story with agony. It was a good story, but writing it would hurt like the most elaborate form of suicide I could imagine. As devastating as daring to look at what I refused to see, only to see...

"Fuck," I breathed, as the trembling hit me. I came that close to looking. Tearing my mind away from the precipice, I came face to face with another painful realization. It didn't matter if it was a real story about a real life.

That thought, at that moment, was more than enough to make me check my sanity at the door and share the full measure her apprehension of mortal peril. Questioning the reality of her story was tantamount to questioning her reality--not a good thing for my sanity at this point. And a moot point. The truth was, it did not matter if the story had its own reality, because it was real to her--and she would always been real to me.

But these thoughts did not pass in an instant as they so conveniently do in stories. She came to some conclusion on her own in the silence. Her eyes still scanning her private horizon, still measuring the height and breadth of her untold story. Her question snapped the silence, oddly close to the mark of my own mused image. "Or is what I've been through enough?"

"Would it matter if it was just a dream? I am the story; if I put it out there, could it take my place? Why do the books really matter... or was my reaction the point?" she shared her question in a way I found difficult to take part in. "I would not be here without them. That's the only thing they changed."

I shook my head slowly, and swallowed; mouth dry. "I'm sorry," I apologized for the interruption and held up a hand, "I'm getting thirsty." I found my way to the kitchen, and a cabinet stocked with glasses, stopping at the sink to pour myself a drink. I went ahead and poured her one too, not bothering to ask. It was a small interruption, but enough for me to gather my thoughts. As I sat her glass on the coffee table before her I began to speak quietly.

Chapter 4

"I am going to apologize first, and ask you to let me finish before you continue. Or leave, if I offend you," I pleaded, serious and sincere. She shrugged, then nodded slightly. "Good. First thing. What is the point of all of this?" I asked, since our conversations had barely touched on what she expected from me in any specific terms.

She stared at me a moment, either unsure of what I meant or how to answer. I don't know which and she didn't ask me to clarify. She just reached for her glass and took a sip.

"The story is the only point," she said after a long silence. I took that to mean that the doubts she had just expressed, and the implications we'd been flirting with, could be pushed back for now. I took a moment to collect myself, easing back from the edge I'd been teetering on--before they had me raving.

"Then what is all of this you are trying to tell me? This stuff about the beginning... is this for the story? Do I need to keep track of what you've been saying?" I asked. It was a legitimate concern, but there was more to it than this question. There was a more logical problem, as I tried to explain, "There is a tremendous difference between just telling a story and writing a book. You need to establish the context. There has to be a point of departure. There has to be some kind of common ground. If the point is for people to read this, then they have to be able to understand what it is you are telling them."

"Which is why I am telling you the beginning," she began, but I cut her off.

"What kind of beginning is saying there really isn't a beginning. Or, the beginning is somehow not there until the end?" I protested.

"But that is the whole point," she declared, setting down her glass. "I know the whole thing is a paradox. It should never have happened, except that I was in a position to understand exactly what I was doing, and yet, I'd have to describe the whole of creation to explain how it was even possible to do what I did. I never realized how difficult it would be to talk about it until I tried just now."

I sighed. "I could have told you that straight off. I've been hammering at it for decades, just grokking the paradox, but I was just working up to that point when you jumped ahead of me. Technically, the paradox has no beginning, because the moment you described is eternal. I've written it out several times, but never once considered it a place I could start the story.

"But, that's okay. A writer can start a story any damn way he pleases. All he needs to accomplish is catch the reader's attention. It's sort of funny, but in a sense the problem with your beginning is like what you said. People choose not to know a lot of things, like the truth, but in the ways that count they can acknowledge it easily.

"People know that beginnings are illusions. The writer realizes that the reader knows this and contrives to make the beginning slip past the reader. A good beginning sucks the reader into the story before he or she notices it. It's the same thing you were saying about listening. So the problem with your beginning is that it makes the reader ask too many questions."

"Is there ever anything but questions at the beginning?" she mused softly, fingers resting lightly on the rim of her drink. Looking up, she flicked her other hand up dismissively. "If it bothers you so much, start at the end. You already know that part."

I gazed back into her stormy eyes. "You mean this."

Her response was delivered with a wry grin, "If you like to jump in at the deep end."

It was hard not to laugh and shake my head. "Just smack the reader with the impossible and dance around the possibility of an explanation?" I asked a bit peevishly. She just shrugged and gave a slight nod. "Are you sure you're not just here to mess with my reality? If I heard you right, you expected the books to be written when you chose to confront me. I'm guessing it wasn't to get my autograph," I challenged.

She frowned, "There is a lot I am still sorting out. Maybe I just wanted to be sure no one was messing with my reality. I had a harder time finding you than I expected, and some doubts once I found out the books didn't exist. Most of my questions were answered the instant we started talking, but that also got me thinking out loud.

"It's clear to me you could write the stories, but the notion of helping you was off the cuff. I've never seriously contemplated how I would go about telling my whole story; I've only ever talked about specific parts," she leaned back and stared at the ceiling. "I'm sorry. I guess I was just testing you and got caught up in it."

"I've read the books, so I already know where you start them. You knew that when you challenged me," she disputed. "Just as you know my true motive for being here. I did a pretty bad job of hiding it, talking about how I'm only here because I dared to look myself in the eye and know myself," she confided, rising to her feet with her drink in hand.

She took a sip as she resumed pacing. "So, I know; truly, if I want my story told, I must ask you to write it."

I frowned and crossed my arms. "Something seems to be missing there," I pointed out.

She nodded, "It is a kind of paradox. You still don't want to see it, but I can only assume that you knew what you were doing all along. Either that, or in the end the story of my life is just a dream. A horrible truth when you face it." She bowed her head, her hair flowing forward to veil her face.

A cold shock raced down my spine.

"You are the end of me," she confided softly, "and I was your hope for a beginning."

I blinked and the world shifted on its axis. Turns out, I didn't have to look. I realized I was dreaming. I didn't have to wake up for my heart to start breaking. I knew in that instant what she had been trying to tell me, what she had already discovered for herself. Why I knew her story. Why I tried a thousand times to write it and always found it too painful.

"I think I know how you got here. I didn't want write it. I couldn't write it. I did not want to do this to you... to me," I whispered.

"Oh, but you must. If you don't, I may as well have never existed, and then how could I know my own story?" she demanded, reaching out and taking my arm in her hands. "Do not doubt for an instant how well you know me--how well I know myself. Even as I am undone, I see why I could never turn a blind eye to the truth; you always see the truth in me."

That said it all, no one could force me to see what I always knew to be true. She simply came to wake me up, though it could cost her everything she was. My dream was on its dying breath, and I always knew deep down that the girl of my dreams was the girl I dreamed of being. A girl who chose to face the truth and die--if necessary--instead of living out a lie, and this is where her story begins.



I woke up from that revelation, drowning an anguished scream. I'd confronted myself in my dreams before, though not in that exact role. The hardest dreams to wake up from, were the ones where I was whole. On the worst days, I don't actually wake up. I just slip into character, becoming the person the world at large knows. I've played that part so often, I tend to maintain it now even in dreams. I could not help dwelling miserably on the fact that in this dream, I managed to embrace the two desperate fictions of my life.

Both of which I'd constructed consciously out of necessity. It had never been my intention to deceive myself. In the first case, I was simply trying to live up to the expectation to be something I wasn't. In the second, well, I'd really have to explain the first before it could begin to make sense. The aftermath of the dream takes precedence.

This was one of those dreams that seem unforgettable at the time, but the truth is that my memory of dreams is best when I'm on the verge of dreaming. It didn't help that reality was never kind to me in the morning. It rarely gave me time to reflect on my dreams, and that morning was no exception. So, I dragged myself out of bed and into the shower. As hard as I fought it, the dream slipped away. A job demands sacrifices, and mine took her attempt to reach me that day.

It was not the first time, and it would not be the last. The day itself was not memorable, but at the time I was working, busy learning, and living in a place of my own. It was pretty mean living; the threat of homelessness loomed close enough to goad me into action. My options weren't great, but I did what I could. I saved my complaints for my journal, occasionally posting them to my blog. I sometimes wrote fanfiction, or chased my muse in illustration.

Though the story was always on my mind, I was too distracted at that point in my life to write anything more evolved than notes. In full consciousness, I was well aware that the whole story was a means for me to escape from the insidious nightmare of my life. In the world's eyes, I have an identity problem, which is ironic, because I never had a problem with my identity. I simply was not who or what I appeared to be.

It was trying to live up to other people's expectations that drove me crazy.

As a child, it did not take me long to discover that reality was not kind to people like me, especially if we called attention to ourselves. As an adult, I've been told by many people to write about being transgendered, but my conundrum was never that simple. Based on my understanding of who I am, I knew at the least I should be a girl. I could not fathom what possessed anyone to think of me as a boy until I was old enough to read and understand an anatomy book.

The thing is, I did not stop understanding myself there. I had an exact sense of who I was, and the determination to find out what I needed to be in order to be true to myself. That has always been the fine point. Playing along was a practical compromise, enforced by social conventions. As far as I was concerned, though, there was no acceptable alternative to being true to myself.

I did not start out with a clear mental image. I stumbled across it in pieces, recognizing in other people which traits complimented the aspects of me that were contradicted by what I had. Every facet of identity that I discovered and failed to embody was an excruciating blow as, bit by bit, I was denied a true place in reality.

Instead, I had this false reality imposed on me. At the time I thought this was normal; for all I knew we were all forced into our roles in life. I blamed myself for resisting. In penance, I took it as a challenge. I was perceptive, intuitive, imaginative and associative. I was a natural student of human psychology and a capable actor. To be accepted, I played the part nature provided.

I was a sociable thing, though, and I had a strong sense of integrity. So, I longed to participate more fully and it killed me to know I was faking. As hard as it was to repress my true nature, I despaired over the fact that my true feelings marked me as a freak. I never wished to be the person I posed as, but I did feel obligated to face facts--even if all but one was against me.

The most critical fact was a simple truth I learned from the whole experience. I actively had to participate in the process or the process would not work. If I lost sight of my true self, I completely lost focus. The lights stayed on but nobody was home. It was nice. Peaceful. Then something kicked my mind into gear and I was me again--and not particularly happy about it.

Inevitably, I just couldn't bear all that self-denial. I took refuge in my imagination, stimulated by comics, movies and books. Initially, I was like the naked goddess, a ghost haunting other people's dreams. The ideas that sparked my imagination became stepping stones to a world that could encompass everything, up to and including me--as impossible as that seemed to be.

I gained a strange insight into godhood, as the creator of my own world. I was troubled by one little problem. As a goddess, I was as much of an outsider to the people who lived in my realm--for exactly the opposite reason--as I was in the world where I was born. I was present in every aspect of my creation, but my participation in life was always an act.

I could only interact with people inside my creation by pretending to be one of them. Confronting them as a goddess tended to explode their heads. That taught me the burden of power as deeply as my other role taught me about powerlessness. I could dictate terms, but as many authors discover, characters have wills of their own. In the realm of the mind, if you build it they really will come. If you respect them, they'll make it real on their own--riddled with flaws and humanity.

Tending to my inner world, I became a student of social psychology, philosophy, religion and magic. I learned as much on those subjects, studying my inner world, as I did studying them from my perspective in the outer world. My private study expanded to encompass physical science--the best understood aspect of our reality--medicine, art and writing. All of this as a pre-teen, and mostly because I was determined to find a way to be me.

Well, I had a way to be me, and that eventually evolved into the story, but I still had to face reality. As a prisoner of my own body, I had no hope of really living, so the only practical thing to do was see if I could change my body. I pursued this goal in secret, well aware that it would be seen by most people as an abnormal--possibly pathological--pursuit. I tried to keep up with the demands and responsibilities of life on the side.

Obviously, this was too much for one individual. I did okay in school, growing up--until I had to balance it with work. I tried to compromise by pursuing a creative career in art or writing. I would have made a great actor, but honestly, adding other characters on top of the ones I already maintained would have been a ridiculous strain on my psyche. I worked on art and writing independently when paying the bills took precedence over education.

In practical terms, I was trying to do at least four full time jobs and barely getting paid for one. I had to give priority to my key pursuit: Fix body soonest. It was a disappointing pursuit, though. Medicine was a few generations away from reshaping a body to the extent I required. True, it was possible to seek cosmetic gender reassignment surgery in combination with hormone replacement therapy, but only at great personal, social and financial cost.

I looked into it. It pushed me to the brink of suicide. Enough said. I never gave up on the impossible. No one on Earth is in a position to definitively rule out possibilities conventional understanding can only regard as magical or miraculous. I could speculate very well on what could produce the precise results I sought, assuming I could establish a viable working context. With better resources, I can be surprisingly articulate and precise in describing it.

Sadly, the last thing I had was suitable resources. I was struggling just to cobble together the requirements to be able to support myself as an artist. I would have focused on establishing myself as a writer, but I became dubious of my chances of getting published when most of my writing was commandeered to work out theories for my main pursuit. Who reads heavy speculative, sometimes erotic, gender-bending, paradoxical, philosophical, sci-fantasy adventure epics?

I'm not saying there's not an audience. I do read fan fiction. I'm just saying it seemed unlikely I'd be supporting myself well enough to survive writing it. I had better chances of winning the lottery, and I don't even play. So, I was in a pretty grim place when I confronted myself in that dream. It did not prompt me to write the story, but as I drifted toward sleep one night, weeks or months later, the memory of the dream came back to me and I was able to write down a hasty version of it.

Not long after that, I confronted myself about it. This time without the fig leaf of a dream. It wasn't the first time I'd used my ability to split my attention to confront myself in my usual roles. It just evolved naturally out of constantly trying to be someone I'm not, while enduring constant conflict between my self-image and my physical form. It's painful, so one day I just stepped out of my head.



On that night, I was sitting at my computer at the end of a long, frustrating day, unable to focus on art or writing. I was too hyped up on caffeine to consider sleep, and too exhausted to think. Too many of my demons had come out in the story, and it was proving impossible to uproot them. I leaned back in my chair and tried to clear my head, and felt myself step out.

It's not astral travel; it's just that the world I perceive is perceived in my head. Since the world is intruding on my domain, I'm free to wander in spirit while my body holds me wherever I am.

I treat that as ground zero and, when writing, refer to my other self in the third person. I don't confuse myself as much when I come back later to read it. As she poked around my apartment, stretching her phantom limbs, I turned my eyes back to the screen and resumed wondering why I persisted in thinking I was trying to write a story. It was more auto-therapy in practice.

Chapter 5

"A story is as good a way to organize your thoughts as anything else," she pointed out, poised in the shadows in the doorway to my bedroom. Playing the part of my conscience, I concluded. That, or devil's advocate. Either way, didn't matter; she was me. I did this when thinking normally wasn't getting me anywhere. While I waited to see where she was going, I start typing everything down.

That came in handy, later, when I needed to open up about all of this. I could not help thinking about the dream at that moment. In particular, that I could not claim she didn't really exist without implying the same of me. She was in my mind, and of my mind, so I did not try to look at her. She could not be seen, not in the flesh anyway, but it's not like I had to look at her to see her perfectly.

"It's been a long time since you've done this, though," she observed, watching me carefully. I could tell there was something on her mind. I felt it. Technically, it was on my mind, but I'd long since learned that her thoughts were her own when she choose to assert herself. Another quirk of being in two places at the same time--at the moment, a way to step outside the box and look at what I'd become.

"That's because it takes more effort than thinking," I respond distractedly while typing. "Even if it is no more contrived than any other thing written; it isn't really a story," I referred back to the problem I was currently having with my writing. I did not have to add that this manner of confronting myself was one of the reasons my stories never got finished; she knew it as well as I.

"It helps when you need someone to talk to, though," she argued, crossing the room to sprawl on the couch next to my desk. This was one of those times when I wished I could have visual

hallucinations; it would be nice to really see her when she troubled to try and fit herself into the world. Instead, I could only see her in the way I see what I am reading about in books, from everywhere and nowhere.

Of course, with her, there was no book, no words; she was self-rendered thought. Ignoring my musing, she continued her own, "It gives me chance to be myself, too."

"You mean, get some distance from being like this," I amended somewhat bitterly, in reference to all the unpleasant facts of my reality. Normally, I did not have the patience to write when we talked like this. Once I discovered I could split my attention two or three ways, it did not take long to become good enough at it that I would just talk to myself when I needed someone to talk to.

I could confront any part of myself that way, even the parts that were smarter and wiser than I can normally be. I came to believe that this was what angels and demons were, projections of ourselves, impressions of others and the personification of our hopes, fears, beliefs and doubts. It's what I thought of as five-dimensional thinking. "So, what do I need to talk about?"

"I've been thinking about what you posted yesterday," she answered. I shook my head slightly, with a grim smile. I'd followed up my dream recap post with a bit of a rant on my blog. Opening a new browser, I found the post and re-read it.

Impulse

July 25, 2009 — eyeofparadox

Who am I? Why am I here? What is the point of my existence? These are questions we all ask at some point in our lives, and we can go our entire lives without knowing the answer. I suspect that a lot of people try to avoid thinking about it, not knowing how to begin answering, and I wonder how long a person can go without asking them. There are an endless number of situations and circumstances that can force a person to confront these questions--and other soul searching questions like them.

For me, these questions can come up as a result of gender issues, but I've had it come up in many other circumstances. The answers, whatever they are, test the limits of my understanding, because in many ways I am just this awareness brought into focus by the sum and gestalt of my understanding. In the scope of my understanding, I am aware that I am not driven by a mere desire to be female. I am driven by an impulse that is at once too simple and too complex for words, because words will never serve to express that impulse. It took root when I found myself in a body I could not express myself properly in. It was only natural for me to become obsessed with finding a better way to express myself.

I put a lot of thought and effort into figuring out the best way to embody myself in human terms, and because I was thinking in human terms, my self image is based on understanding which compromises with reality allowed me to be as true to myself as possible. Of course, human limitations are based on the limitations of reality, which are the perceived limits of existence--or rather the limits of perception. The plain, simple and painful truth is that I am driven to do something that cannot be done within those limits--as we understand them.

I am a person who would have to change the world in order to show myself in it. It is who I am, it is why I am here, and the end--the point--is to have a beginning. It took a long time to understand that I was not limited by what anyone else knew or understood about reality; I can only be limited by my own understanding. At the same time, I realized that people understand a great deal more than they know, and that the truth is pretty much always hidden in plain sight. As I began to see and understand more, I felt the temptation to try to share what I discovered and help enlighten others.

I got side tracked trying to figure out how to describe and explain what I perceived, losing sight of my original purpose. I do not need anyone to tell me that what I intended to do was "impossible" and I got tied up in wanting to be able to explain how to do the impossible before I threw everything I had into trying to do it. I was focused on breaking down the impossibility of it, identifying precisely what had to occur to achieve what I intended. In spite of myself, I ended up spending a lot of time thinking about how impossible it was to do what I needed to do.

I should have obeyed my original instinct, and followed my intuition. I let myself get hung up on the consequences of doing the impossible. The question has come up enough in fiction, I had to consider what would happen if I succeeded. To truly be me, I had to stop being the person I appeared to be. I did not know how to do that without hurting people I loved.

I was also bothered by the deeper implications of what I intended, and the peculiar insight that motivated me to act. I intended to transform my body, but that was simply how I intended to use the power I perceived in myself, how I would truly show myself. Expressing a power like that would literally change the world. It was never my intention to change the world, but I found myself in a position where it was necessary in order to be true to myself.

This is what Morpheus was talking about when he told Neo, "There is a difference between knowing the path and walking it."

I know it sounds insane, and I'm not inclined to convince anyone that it is not. This is mostly a case of me thinking aloud and not much caring who hears. I have spent

decades trying to figure out what it would take to accomplish this task, and discovering where I am obstructed by a lack of knowledge, or experience, or resources. I've shared bits of speculation in past journals and blogs, and explored the concepts in my fiction, but I can never really capture my thoughts in words. Writing allows me to slow my thoughts down and get some of them out where I can focus on specific ideas.

I needed to get to the root of what was really bothering me, and even if it sounds crazy, I am more comfortable with what I have said in this post than I have been with any of the posts about being transgendered or needing to transition. Those other posts have forced me to revisit the things that have torn me apart, but in the hope of being understood and accepted I tried to stay within the bounds of what seemed socially acceptable.

The problem is that transition falls bitterly short of accomplishing what I really need to do. I have paid a huge price to give myself time to think this through, and for the second time in my life been tempted by the practical alternative and found the cost in terms of personal compromise to be too high. It was never an option, because I always believed in myself, even when that belief was undermined by all the doubt in the world. If I cannot act on that belief, is there really any point to living?

"Okay, that's still weird," she blurted, as she shared in my reading. Clearing her head with a violent shake, she continued, "Anyway; it's as much my post as it was yours," she sighed and scooted closer to the opposite arm of the couch, tucking her feet under herself. "I know what it has to sound like to anyone who reads it, and if people have trouble understanding and accepting me, well..." She could not finish the thought, because I already knew what she was going to say.

"People have a hard time understanding and accepting those different from themselves. It took me too long to realize that there is nothing I can do to make anyone understand or accept me. People have to take it upon themselves to understand anything, and it is impossible to truly accept what is not understood.

"I am inclined to think that an inability to accept something is in fact proof that you do not truly understand it," I found myself declaring. I'd been unable to understand what was expected of me as a child, and so the role imposed on me was unacceptable. When I learned enough to understand what made me a boy, I also understood that I never had a choice, and that was unacceptable.

When I worked it out enough to realize I also had no power to change what I was, that too was unacceptable. It lead me to ask some devastating questions. What was the point of being able to choose if you were not given a choice--especially about something that practically defined you? What was the point of living if you were given a life you did not want?

"I am not the only one to suspect that there has to be more to life than this, or that there is more to us, for that matter," I told her, in response to her unstated concern for what was at the heart of that post.

She tilted her head and shrugged in agreement, picking at imaginary lint on her skirt. "I know, but I did not stop at that, did I?" I felt her studying me. I can't really meet her eyes, but I could imagine myself looking over at her, seeing thoughts written on her face.

"I know, some of this is impossible to put into words, but yeah, the post was really about believing in myself and the impulse to act on that belief," I admitted, picking up on the thoughts this little game was bringing to the surface with a small sigh. "Although, there really is nothing hard about changing the world.

"The world changes with or without our help. What is hard is getting the results you intended. I might have gone out on a ledge by saying what I wanted to do, or why I wanted to do it. If there was a problem with what I posted, it was not being able to say how it could be done."

She pulled her knees up to her chest and hugged them. Our thoughts, though divided, were identical. I was not able to invest the time and effort needed to figure that out. "The hard part is not figuring out how it can be done. There's plenty of scope for the imagination there," she insisted, prompting me to think of thousands of stories I've read, and hundreds I've tried to write, where suitable means were presented.

"No, the trick is establishing that there are means and methods available, and pushing ourselves beyond our current understanding. It is kind of hard to work on that if it is not your job, though," I laughed, bitterly. Of course, there was no job like that. Just another reason I'd been totally lost in this world. That sobered me up. "Honestly, even the little I've managed to find time to think about would take a lot of writing, and I don't need another 'job' I don't get paid to do!"

"And yet you sit up all night writing... are you planning to blog this?" she teased.

"Until I figure out what to do, what will make a difference, I don't really have anything better to do," I pointed out tiredly. As usual, I'd barely scratched the surface of all the things that were on my mind. She'd been patient enough for me to keep up typing, but writing our thoughts down was too slow and time consuming a way to deal with anything.

She looked at me, knowingly, and I shrugged. "Things have to be done in their own way. If this were a story, I could skip over all the deep thinking. Even in a simple blog post, I could just focus on making a point. You intended to ask me how this is going to work. What you really want to know is how much more of this you have to endure."

I closed my eyes and leaned back in my chair. I knew what it would take to set her free, and that I had to find it in myself. The problem was, as long as I was not her, I couldn't really be me. I rolled my head to the right and looked at her. She could not be seen, but she would not let that stop her.

An obvious truth, always staring me in the face.



While he typed in his final observation and submitted the post, I contemplated the oddity of being admired by him. Did that say something about how far life pushed me away from myself? I did not have time to think about it that night, but it touched on something I dwelt on often. As embarrassing and difficult as it was to explain, it was just another bizarre paradox, and a natural consequence of my life.

I mean, consider the situation. In purely physical terms, I was just one of the guys. I may have had to work at it, but the best way to lie is to convince yourself. To play the part of a boy, I needed to be masculine. I figured out how to do that, because I was raised with five other boys. By the time puberty hit, I'd filled in most of the blanks marked "male" in my psyche.

In order to become male in my own mind--the hardest, and most dangerous part of my act--I had to ignore my true identity. In short, I became a different person. Method acting. I didn't exactly forget who I was, I just had to willfully ignore me. Serious "there is no spoon" mental mojo. I just wasn't cut out to sit still and be silent, though.

Did I mention; red hair?

Right, so, when I was deep into character, I was completely disengaged from reality. I got bored sitting out on the sidelines and prowled along the edges of my cage. I distracted the hell out of the part of me that was caught up in his role. Since his identity hinged on my denial, he had to reinterpret my presence in his thoughts in a situationally appropriate way. Well, the situation was, he had a penis and testosterone--and a mandate to be a man.

It's not surprising at all that he became obsessed with me.

It was kind of cute, actually; in a totally perplexing, mortifyingly "why is this turning me on?" kind of way. At times, yes, that really freaked me out. It was never less than baffling, but on occasion it was amusing as hell. What played out in reality was almost tragic, but from my side, it was a teenage sex comedy of epic proportions, and no one knew about it but me.

He participated, and struggled to keep it out of the story, and ultimately gave up on the story to save face. But, the truth doesn't need to assert itself. It's content to be silent and wait. I needed him to

survive reality, so I remained... tried to remain patient, and prayed. There were days I wanted to kill myself out of frustration, but somewhere I found inner peace.

Even at times when I seemed to surrender completely to my harsh reality, I was living--growing--and thriving. I accepted the sacrifice and suffering of my Earth-bound alter ego as the price I paid for the freedom to dream myself into existence. It was never going to be easy, and in strict, rational terms, it was outright insane.

I didn't care. If I limited myself to pure reason, I would have been forced to admit life was hopeless, as pointless and cruel as it appeared to be. But, who knew better than I how deceptive appearances could be? I only suffered inside the box, and I've only ever lived in my own reality. If the truths I know are limited, depending entirely on the survival of my body; when that body dies, my whole universe dies along with it.

In that case, the best I could ever hope to do was to share my story; to be voice of that universe, and invite other dreamers to share it. The only way I could do that was by inspiring the person I must become to carry the burden of that body. Not so easy when that person was founded on lies, and discovered it was suicide to keep lying to herself. She stumbled. She tripped. She stepped into a crossfire. She almost gave up on her dream.

Hard to blame her; it had to seem smarter than dying for it. So, I took a step back and watched over her. I bit my tongue when she struggled to do the practical things, while the story gathered dust. Some of what she did would draw criticism. But in her own way, she was pursuing a better dream; a very high stakes gamble, but hell, I cheered her on.

Over the course of things, she was losing her will to live. She'd lost the knack of ignoring herself, but somehow she managed to salvage the man in her when the lie came completely unraveled.

Chapter 6

There had been an unintended consequence to confronting myself. On one level, because I took the message to heart, I no longer needed to lie to myself. I was who I was. I wasn't normal by any stretch of the imagination, and I remained a living contradiction. I still faced the impossible on two sides. In reality, I had to change the world to be the same in body as I am in spirit. In truth, my spirit would break if I truly conformed to reality.

Rock, meet hard place.

I remained in the exact same place I started. I am not who I appear to be, but I have to live up to that appearance to function in society on a daily basis. I had options. There are always options, if you consider it. I could have simply asserted myself in spite of everything. By that, I mean, simply live, no compromises. In many ways, that's exactly what I did. The people I dealt with still saw a man, and treated me as one. The habit of being one was what carried me through situations--on a superficial level--on a daily basis.

I tried not to let that bother me. I opened up to people who took enough interest to ask. Admitting that they could not quite understand it, most were willing to just accept I was odd. Good people. I even got over the failure of a relationship that choked on my--our?--appearance. He was a writer and a dreamer, and he confronted me with a paradox I still boggle at. I first contacted him in response to his writing. I acted on impulse--in response to a feeling; a silly, kind of embarrassing thing, really.

He reminded me of the man of my dreams.

Ten years earlier, in what was roughly our tenth IRC chat, he insisted on knowing what my problem was. Our initial connection had been Ranma 1/2 fanfiction, so we'd already talked about gender issues. It was something he'd struggled with too. I gave in to his insistence, confiding that my identity conflict merely hinged on gender, encompassing every facet of my being. He pressed for an explanation and I described myself fully to him.

To our mutual shock, he recognized the description intimately. I was--in spirit--the embodiment of the girl of his dreams. OMFG... WTF? AYFS! I hesitate to go into the details, because this part is as much his story as mine. It isn't my place to tell his side, but I can say this was a mind-bending challenge for both of us. We tested and probed, consistently finding more common threads. If our dreams and stories were not literally connected, their resonance provided its own connection.

Nothing in reality supported our bond, and the presentation of our stories was not identical. The similarity was essentially spiritual. An underlying truth was a real possibility, reinterpreted through our unconscious minds. I weighed my doubts and balanced my suspicions; but the one thing I knew for certain was that reality denied it. It was something outside the box. All that mattered, in the end--and for whatever reason, was, I had a relationship with someone on the basis of who I truly was.

I found comfort in the fact that, even in reality, a significant number of people are open to the prospect of soul mates--in spite of uncertainty that souls even exist. It wasn't that I fell in love with him; rather, I'd found the one I love. I agonize over his circumstances in life every bit as much as my own. I knew that in practical terms, our relationship was doomed; but, I still tried to pursue it.

I put it off for about eight years, and then finally I committed. I packed up and moved to be with him, and... well, it didn't work out. In spite of what we shared--what we would always share--reality still stood between us. I found a job and a place to live, and tried to endure the frustration. A year or more passed, before I had that dream. The changes I went through, throughout those days, went for the most part unnoticed.

To sum it all up, I was heartbroken. The irony. I always expected my downfall would come when my spirit broke. I guess we all have our blind spots. Looking back on it later, I saw by that point in my life, my spirit was damn near invulnerable. My weak spot, unnoticed throughout my life, was my heart. I love things deeply, passionately and unconditionally. Though I hated my circumstances as intensely, I loved life unreservedly. I denied my self for the love of the family that took me in as a child.

I loved a man I had dreamed of, and left him rather than impose the harshness of my reality on him. I even loved the man in me, though it all but destroyed me to be him. I loved the world--and the people--I dreamed up to escape from reality. I loved them enough to share my story--insane as it was--even if writing it killed me. So, I dropped this burden on top of everything I struggled with, overlooking what made it the final straw.

I should have picked up on it immediately, but--again--I had a blind spot. Usually, once I made up my mind to do something, I became committed to it. At the time, I thought I was just trying to be practical. Metaphorically killing myself to write a story was completely different from not being able to survive as a consequence of working on the project. Since my job prospects were turning sour, I moved back home to finish my degree and find a job that would support me.

I set forth with determination, but the unintended consequence kicked in. Confronting myself the way I had, staring the truth in the face, I did not just stop trying to hide from the truth. I allowed myself to admit that the reason for all of my suffering was because I was that truth. My doubts and beliefs were beside the point. It hurt to be denied by fact, but I suffered because the method I used to get by in life required me to deny myself.

I was not completely incapacitated. As I struggled to reorganize my life and find a way to make a living, I noticed that the experiences and habits I picked up as a guy remained. I'd been forced to call on my family for help getting back on my feet. I found that I could still play the part of the brother and son I became for them. He was not me, but he existed within me. I could almost just run on autopilot and focus on the specific task at hand.

I guess the clearest way to express it was that I didn't try to believe I was him. I did not need to get out of his way in order for him to help me. That old trick of dividing my mind meant we could work together to get through the day. I still faced the same level of frustration with my body, and I still wished I could devote myself to changing it. At the same time, I understood, even with that power at my disposal I would still have a problem to resolve.

I have had an "In Case of Miracle" internal think-tank running in the back of my brain since I was a child. Many of my early stories were variations on facing the consequences of a real transformation. Doubt, disbelief and denial presented the biggest challenges. So, the likely consequence of changing would be the same as appearing from nowhere. I would have no legal identity, no citizenship, no rights, etc.

Funny that I'd be worried about that when any rational person would be focused on the seemingly more immediate question: is there any power at my disposal?



"At the rate you're going, you'll be homeless in a couple of weeks," he admonished me as I set down my coffee. He doesn't exist apart from me, but he lives in my mind. I've leaned on him for years, and long before we faced the truth, he made it clear he would rather die than live in a world without me. For most of my life, I talked to him to get through to myself. From time to time, he was choosing to assert himself in order to speak to me.

I suppressed a tired smile, "He speaks."

Laughter rumbled out of him. That wasn't the response he expected. "I'm just saying, it's been five years. I know things were difficult, and that you had a lot of distractions to deal with, but you were in a better position to write anytime over the last three years. You waited until you were on the verge of living on the street to start writing?"

I took in a deep breath and let it out in a hard sigh. "I was a panic attack away from hitting the streets almost every minute of those past three years," I reminded him. I did not have to say that it was not fear or concern about the hardships that action entailed that kept me from bailing.

"I can remember a few nights you did crack and run. I'm sorry the emergency room visit went the way it did. Three thousand dollars is a lot to pay for a handful of pills, and, 'I'm sorry, but we can't help you,'" he lamented.

"Especially since I only took three of them before I concluded they didn't do anything," I grumbled, rolling my head and listening to the faint crackle in my neck. I wrinkled my nose in annoyance. These exchanges used to be an excuse to step out of body.

"Yeah, well, you never did react to drugs in a normal way. Just about everything makes you try to hack reality," he accused gently. He rested phantom hands on my phantom shoulders, as if the body I was wearing was not there. "You know it's not good to push that way."

I narrowed my eyes and bent my head forward. "I don't see an option that doesn't involve putting more pressure on myself," I protested.

He leaned into my back and wrapped his arms around me. "You do have a knack for crazy. Are you sure you want to write all this down?" he asked, looking at the screen over my shoulder.

I shrugged. "As you pointed out, this isn't a good time to tackle the story. I think I have time to highlight the story behind the story, though. I got the idea when I updated the resume on my old blog." I didn't really need to explain any of this to him, but I felt conversational. "I hadn't looked at my blog in years, so I started reading through my old posts when I was done."

I frowned at my empty coffee cup. I'd been too focused on talking and typing to notice when I finished it. With a rueful shake of my head, I resumed, "I got through The Price of Dreams, remembered there had been more to it, and it clicked. A couple months ago, my therapist suggested I try writing short-fiction; Amazon Singles type of stuff. At the time, I didn't think I had any ideas suited to a short novel."

"I always expected to revisit that scene near the end of the story, but... fully fleshed out, it should work as a novella," I told him.

"You're a few chapters short, I think," he informed me.

"Um. Yeah," I sighed, mentally pushing back from my desk and running my hands through my hair. "I sort of caught up to myself. On the other hand, I'm kind of worried that the next three chapters won't be enough to address all the stuff that came out while writing."

He ruffled my hair and kissed me on top of my head. "Like I said, you do have a knack for crazy."

I took a moment to reflect on what the next step should be. He stepped out for a cigarette and when he came back, he said, "Why don't you just tell me what you've already figured out."

I let out a puff of air and dove into it, "The dream was a turning point. Honestly, there have been many dreams and many writings like it--a recurring theme in my life. I could expand this part of the story if I could track them all down, but... I don't suppose it matters. What matters is... that particular dream served as the inspiration to confront myself in that particular post. That's where I was forced to acknowledge the truth of the story."

"And what is the truth?" he prompted.

I knew the answer but it wasn't easy to phrase. "I have a real knack for crazy?" I joked, to put off answering.

"True, but not the answer to the question. Do you want me to say it?" he reprimanded.

I rolled my eyes. If I tried another snappy comeback, he probably would. But, he wouldn't have asked me to spell it out first unless it was important that I say it. A simple way to express it occurred to me, but I wasn't exactly happy with it. None-the-less, I spit it out, "I'm a figment of my own imagination?"

He scratched his head and shrugged. "I suppose we are all, when you get right down to it, but I think you can do better."

I sighed. "Okay. I feel like I'm probably repeating myself here. The truth of the story is that it's ultimately my story. My imagination unleashed. I used it to figure things out, about myself and about everything. I acted on impulse and instinct and intuition, doing things without thinking about how I did them. I created an omniverse, and learned the consequences of playing with it. I was playing with fire and I didn't even notice. I gave myself access to absolute power."

He studied me silently for a moment before prompting, "Unlimited power?"

I paused with my mouth open. The implications of that question almost slipped by. I cleared my throat and said, "I'm kind of afraid to touch that. My first impulse was to say yes, I saw no reason to limit the scope of my imagination or what I could do with it. But the way you asked..." He had chosen to assert himself right after I'd typed out a question. Had I given myself access to all the power at my disposal? "I don't know."

He raised an eyebrow. "What's wrong with your first impulse? What puts you in doubt?"

"I'm not sure. It seems to be a matter of perspective. In my own mind, I can do whatever I want, but I have to respect certain limits. I have a lot going on in my mind, and all of it takes will. If some whim of mine threatens to compromise a process I respect, I'll defend it. A fight like that can become pretty scary. So, I learned to be conscious of the implications and consequences of using power. Um. I guess the best way to say it is that I am the limit," I shrugged, hoping that was clear enough.

"Now we're getting somewhere. Unfortunately, you're about to pass out." He tried to pry me away from the keyboard and send me to bed, but I refused to go until I finished one last sentence.

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It was early morning when I went to bed, and early afternoon when I woke up. I wanted to get right back to the story, but first I had to answer the call of nature, boot up my computer, brew a cup of coffee and step out for a cigarette to get my brain in gear. I was down to a few six-packs of ramen, a can of chili, a can of tomato soup, an eighth of a jar of peanut butter and a frozen hamburger patty in the kitchen, so I knew I had to go shopping as soon as possible.

I'd be tempted to stop for a pack of smokes, since I'd probably smoke my last two along the way. I did not care for the habit, but aside from the addiction, it was a way to relieve stress. It's been good for my sanity. Alcohol does nothing for me and I'm not into the recreational use of drugs. My "drug" of choice was creativity. If I put off shopping to write, though, I'd just get distracted by hunger and the craving to smoke.

I was tempted to tough it out. I was well past broke. I'd been waiting to get paid for some work I did for a friend. Turned out he was having money problems himself. The money I had was a sort of gift from my brothers--and possibly more than they could afford. I have a generous family, but let's face it, times are hard. We all have to struggle to support ourselves, and money is always a stumbling block.

It does not actually matter how much work you do. Economics is about the value of resources, such as labor, service, and administration, or products, materials and property. Things like talent, perspective, and honesty are incredibly valuable, but only when they can be recognized. A valuable quality must prove itself; it depends on the opportunity to do so, to have a chance to be employed. The

irony is that the most valuable qualities require some practical application before they mature into their true worth.

It's a lesson I learned my first freshman year in college, when I needed a job just to stay in school to become qualified for a decent job. I worked on creating my own opportunities, but the wrong kind of job would cost me more than I earned by disrupting my work. My creative skills withered through years of poverty, then struggled to bloom--in the shadow of working and studying--when I finally went back to school.

The opportunities I'd found since graduating had been both rare and anemic. I made the most of what I could get, but worked more often at finding a job than I worked on paying jobs. Ironically, my most creative period in years had been the last four months--and counting--I'd spent in pursuit of a job. Perhaps that explained why I dwelt on the subject while I was shopping. It had a lot to do with what compelled my current writing, so when I got home I typed gist of it down.

"I sometimes wish the technology to record thoughts had been invented," I sighed, as I settled in to resume the conversation I'd interrupted. "Writing them down after the fact, I always feel like the best parts get lost."

"Not so much lost as not shared," he pointed out. "It's a trade off. If you record a stream of consciousness, the best parts can get lost in the chaos we call thinking."

I hummed in agreement. Clearing my mind of distractions, I focused on where we left off when he sent me to bed that morning. "The last thing you said was that we were getting somewhere, but where exactly were we getting?" I asked.

He settled in and composed his thoughts before answering. "You figured out that the dream was about acknowledging the truth of the story. Being in conflict with--and unable to do anything to change--reality forced you to create your own reality. The life you lived presented you with possibilities and challenges, concepts and doubts that you wrestled with in your imagination. The power you played with might have been limited to yourself, but you accepted the consequences of playing with it.

"Last night you were debating a point that you were not ready to write down," he diverged to address what prompted him to confront me. "It was something along the lines of; children are better than adults at understanding magic. Adults have to know how it works before they're willing to accept it, but kids can accept that something makes it work--they just want to have access to it. So, while the adult asks, 'How does this fit in with what I know?', the kid asks, 'What do I have to know so I can do this?'"

I nodded, grateful that he was able to put the thoughts into words. "I think people would get a lot further with understanding things if they had the same attitude as kids," I smiled, remembering that thought had been very clear in my head.

He nodded back, "Right. Now, as it happens, that's exactly what you did. You pictured the result you sought and you worked out what was required in order to achieve it. You did that over and over, every time you confronted a problem, and all of that became an influence on the story." Without breaking stride, he changed tracks, "Going back to last night, you also observed that there's an implicit question that should be asked if you're talking about power in reality."

I knew exactly what he was talking about. "Yes. It's so easy to get caught up in how this or that is not possible in reality. But, before you struggle with the notion of having the power to change reality, you first have to ask: What is reality? That's a tough question and you can get lost in it, devote lifetimes to the question and never come up with a definitive answer.

"As far as concepts go, reality gets pretty elusive, but that's because people think too light on the definition and too hard on the description. The thing about reality is that it is presented to us as an accomplished fact. How the hell does that happen?" I demanded rhetorically. "It implies that any requirements essential to the process have already been met. The potential is a given, but what is it?

"Reality can hardly be a prerequisite for the potential of reality, so we have to be open to the possibility that reality is not a prerequisite for existence but more a condition of existence," I speculated. "A lot in that to think about, but as far as we're concerned here, the question to explore is: What is required for something to be real? What does it take for something to become real?"

Chapter 7

"I would hold off on trying to answer that for a moment, to confront what you missed," he told me when I picked up the thread the next day. That's the funny difference between a written scene and reality. Even though I took a break--ate dinner, watched a movie and went to bed, then woke up grateful that Monday was a holiday and I was not obligated to spend the day job hunting--I never really left the point we'd reached in our conversation.

I had an idea of what he wanted to address, since I could hardly ignore what was on his mind as he smoked a cigarette before he let me start writing. "Since you insist on bringing it up, I might as well admit you've already got me thinking about it," I teased, allowing myself a smile.

He responded by giving me a mental shake. "I don't mind you dressing the scene--I'm sure the reader appreciates it--but see if you can do us both a favor and try not to get distracted." I rolled my eyes and urged him to spell it out. "This part of the story can play out one of several different ways. Since you only have a third to go, saying this now could make a huge difference. As you pointed out, reality presents itself to us as an accomplished fact."

He gave me an indirect look in the eyes, and I nodded, so he continued, "That happens also to be what you did when you confronted yourself in the dream. In spite of the fact that you and I were not able to write it, the dream confronted us with the entire story as an accomplished fact in the person of the main character."

I could see his point, and even explain it thus: The story existed in an abstract form somewhere in my subconscious. From the perspective of my avatar, the protagonist of the story, the form it took

was a collection of books in the library of my memory and imagination. What made it real--and paradoxical--for her was accepting the context, and the perspective she was in, as all of us accept reality. "So, you're bringing this up as a way of saying I already have my answer?"

"Almost," he qualified, fidgeting a bit as he wrestled with apprehension. "Let's just say that it serves as an example of subordinate reality. We have to acknowledge that we can't explain the process that put us in a real position to imagine it. Aside from that, and keeping in mind the truth of the story, when you put yourself in her position you made a choice to conform to it that gave her that reality."

I paled. "And that's why confronting me the way she did, she ran the risk of dying."

He nodded. "If you had not been willing to accept what the story proposed, the experience would have destroyed her. Fortunately you weren't embarrassed to admit that you created everything, including her, to express yourself when you had no expression in this reality. So, she was just you coming back to yourself, knowing her existence has meaning."

I grimaced, realizing that in the terms of the story, she woke up trapped in her nightmare. "God, what a horrible ending!"

He shrugged, "If it ended there, it would certainly seem that way. On the other hand, she may have saved your life. Because you had so little hope in life of ever being true to yourself, you've been on the brink of just giving up. It wasn't in you to kill yourself, but if there was one hope that reality promises, it's that one day this life will end. There is no shame in dying if you get too broken to live."

I kind of wanted to cry at that, and for once my body seemed willing to oblige, but I held back the tears and accepted his point, and silently kept typing. I also acknowledged how she saved my life; she convinced me the story was important enough for me to live long enough to tell. I could not help asking, "So, what happened to her?"

"She woke up, and in a way she's carried you for the past five years," he told me.

I blinked at that a few times, trying to wrap my head around what it actually meant in terms of events that filled the years in question. If nothing else, it proved I could surprise myself, and that was something worth noting. "Okay," I protested, pushing the point, "but what I wanted to know is, where is she now? Is she still, well, herself, I guess; and how on Earth can she do that?"

He sighed and pushed up the sleeves of his shirt, and we paused for a moment unable to type; uncertain who was in control. "Talk about obvious explanations," he smirked. "You are who you think you are, and you think as more than one person. Not like, MPD. You wear a persona like a story wears words, and you respect our reality."

I got it at once, but it didn't hurt to spell it out, "I only let myself know what's appropriate for the perspective I'm in. Isn't that sort of like lying to myself?"

"No, it's just following the rules of a game. The point right now isn't to know it all. The truth doesn't need explaining. The purpose of what you've been doing here is to figure out what it takes to do what you ultimately have to do if you have any hope of surviving," he explained. Although that touched on an unspoken truth, he was only elaborating a strategy.

"I swear, every paragraph of this makes me want to jump up and run around screaming," I mumbled.

"Sometimes, that's the price of dreams," he consoled me, "but that's just where things start to get interesting."



I was torn between taking a step back for a bit, and the impulse to keep exploring. I could have just sat there staring into space, or peeled the curtain back to see where all of this was going. I wondered how much of my blindness was just the writer's craft, or if I really fooled myself into ignoring the full grasp of my consciousness. I mean, this story did not have room for the thousands of times I confronted myself--awake or on the edge of sleep--in the guise of one of my personas.

I guess I was taking advantage of the fact that I was being honest through the guise of fiction. Did it hurt to admit how often I talked with my avatar late at night when I could not rest? Was I brave enough to face the consequences of sharing all the paths I took in my search for a practical miracle? Should I confess my fear that at the end of this tale, there's a gap too wide to jump without a hell of a lot more momentum?

I could almost feel her waiting in the wings, like a silent promise ready to step in as soon as I was ready to hear her. I tried to imagine what it would have been like, to gradually confront godhood and just when you could begin to accept that power, wake up as someone else in this reality. Then I had to slap myself. It wasn't something I had to imagine; I experienced it every morning. An endless stream of tiny drops; so harmless, and so devastating.

"Interesting," I finally said. "Also known as the prelude to awe and terror--and eventually exhaustion."

"A mind has amazing powers, but a brain gets worn out," he noted. I agreed in silence and took a few moments to let my mind settle. I headed downstairs to the kitchen and stared into a cupboard until I found something I cared to eat. I made a couple of peanut butter and jelly sandwiches, and ate them standing at the counter while the cats meowed at me for treats. They always do that, and they were getting kind of fat, so I tried to ignore them.

I stepped outside for fresh air and a smoke--you can enjoy both if you're willing. I contemplated what I'd written so far, wondering if I should try to shape the end or let the surprises keep coming. When the dream sequence ended, it seemed as if my avatar's part in this was over. But if my male alter ego was right, she was capable of putting in another appearance. More important, she could give her perspective on the mystery of creating reality.

I had not come to a decision, nor committed to a plan of action, when I returned to my room and settled in once more at my computer. A few paragraphs was enough to cover my detour from the conversation. Then my brain locked up, so I went back to the start of the chapter. He quietly stepped out--stopped asserting himself--to let me think. As I read, I surprised myself with a few insights into some vintage understandings, and tried to grasp the one that seemed crystallize all of them.

As he pointed out, I was good at acting. I'd always had a talent for putting myself into the mind of another--to think and feel, even identify, as someone else. As I used to say, all the people in my head are me. I've gotten so deep into some of my roles that I trapped myself in them. I was capable of infinite identification, but I truly claimed only one identity. Without it, I have no integrity, no sense of purpose or meaning.

While playing goddess, I discovered I was not limited to conscious identification. I would create a character and unconsciously assume its persona--or something else stepped in and asserted itself. The latter seemed a plausible explanation in the case of more willful characters who made their own decisions--damn the story--and turned into zombies if I tried to force them into line. They may only exist when I look at them, but their spirit--that kind of will--always has a truth of its own.

"You're going to run out of time if you keep staring into your blind spot," she broke in, as I chased my thoughts around in circles.

I clamped down. I couldn't help it. I honestly had not known if she would assert herself, and wasn't prepared for her to be this abrupt. Then I relaxed and tried to go with it. There was only one thing to say, "I know. This is... different from the other times we've talked."

She smiled gently, "Only because this time it could have a consequence you can't see from where you're at."

I shook my head. "I know there's something I'm seeing, I just can't focus on it."

"I told you it was like that," she turned up her smile, showing her teeth in a wide grin. "You are all knotted up with tension. You need to try and relax. I know this is a difficult process, but if you try to control it, it can't play out."

My eyes went wide. "Wow. Isn't that just screaming with implications."

"Perhaps, but we might as well address the problem you've created for yourself," she declared, settling in to discuss something that had always been on my mind. "We both know that you did not set out to write a story. You wanted to have a life in which you were as true to others as you were true to yourself. Your frustration with your situation may have put you on my path, but your intent called for something that could not be satisfied by my life."

I chewed my lip grimly, nodding in resignation. "It wasn't an accident you came back to confront me, and it wasn't because you knew I'd need your help," I acknowledged.

She narrowed her eyes at me, as I edited a thought out. Instead of challenging me, she confirmed at least the first part. "I had to be true to myself. I did not set out to escape reality, I just needed to figure myself out. When I said you were the end of me, it was implicit that you're my beginning as well. That isn't just a linear progression, but a process with continual feedback. The paradox of my story lies in a pocket of time out of phase with your reality."

I blinked and shook my head. "When I try to think about being you, I can never taste the reality. But, whenever you speak to me, it's weird; it really is real for you," I marveled. I could be frank about that. Her perspective of this was radically different from mine as a writer. I couldn't resist giving her a mental poke and asking, "How the hell do you do it?"

She sighed and rolled her eyes, finishing off with a tilt of her head. "There's no trick. I'm just being me," she replied, ironically quoting her signature line.

"Unbelievable," I muttered, gesturing for her to continue.

She raised an eyebrow, almost shrugged, and chuckled, "I see why you get so distracted. And would you please stop trying to peek into my head--or planning your thoughts--and just listen?"

I sucked in a deep breath through my nose, and apologized, "I'm sorry. I can feel you think and things keep catching my attention."

She wanted to shake her head and mutter, "Unbelievable." When I wrote that down she changed her mind and envisioned throttling me.

"Sorry. Sorry. Trying to write this, remember?"

She composed herself, waving her head. "No. No. You're right; I don't want you to stop writing. There's a reason to get into my head. Just... try to stay focused. Hmm?" I nodded and she took a moment to regain her train of thought.



There was a lot for each of us to consider, so I left her alone and took a moment to gather my perspective. I doubt I could describe the process by which we both could think at the same time without mentally colliding. All I could say was that we returned to our task with different things on our mind. I hit the keyboard and reset the stage, then let her take over.

"I meant to work my way up to this, but that won't make it easier," she began. "I was hoping he would get to address this, and I'm sure he was working up to it. As I already said, your original intent was, in simplest terms, the pursuit of power. You want people to be able to see you for who you really are in reality. You sought the power to physically change, to embody your true identity.

"While forced to conform to reality, you asserted yourself in the best way you could. In truth, you've been acting on many levels, working on multiple angles. You harnessed the power of your imagination, and borrowed liberally from reality. The thing that made your creation real was the extent to which you participated in it. So you became me, but in a way that ultimately forced me to confront you.

She took a deep breath and composed herself to tell me what I knew had been coming, "I'll let the story speak for all I've been through, but through me you confronted power. In the context of your life, it was just the power of imagination; not something that could alter your physical reality. And just so we're clear, that doubt threatens my physical reality--and all of the people I care about. As a facet of you, I can cling to my mental reality and share your ordeal with you."

I could not argue with any of that. The insanity of it did not change the fact that I could only guarantee her reality as a part of me. My own reality was supported only by the fact that I suffered agony if I denied my own identity. I smiled for a moment at the thought of the two of us, trapped in my head, identical in everything but experience. On impulse, I finally had to ask, "Do you actually have a male half? I see him in the story, but I hate the idea I wrote him in as a consequence of my experiences."

When she just raised an eyebrow at me, as if to say, "Seriously?", I apologized for the interruption. She shook her head and smothered a laugh. "How many times are you going to stop me from saying what you're so afraid of?" she asked, then held up a hand to cut off any answer. "It's okay. It's perfectly normal for you to think, if what I went through had been real, I should have had the power to confront you in the flesh and not in dreams."

"Let's be honest," I said, "the truth of it is--and in accordance with the philosophies and theories I explored through you--I hoped to unlock my own power. I hoped to grasp it through you, unconsciously, if I could not confront it consciously. I tried to give you all the power I could access, but that's the thing. The demon of doubt. What power do I have access to?"

She raised her eyebrows and smiled, nodding. "That's a bitch of a question, isn't it?" I gaped at her for a moment, and then we both laughed. When we recovered, she cleared her throat and said, "At the moment, I think it's safe to say you have the power of your mind. That counts for something."

I sighed, but it was as much in relief as in dismay.

"Also," she added, as serious as could be, "if we want to be fair, we should say you have the power of your soul. We could debate what that power can achieve, but it's intrinsic to you; and you are the access." She clasped my upper arms reassuringly. "But, the question comes down to application. In my world, your mind is the foundation of reality. So tell me, what is the foundation of your reality?"

Chapter 8

I had no idea how many people have lived, since the earliest days of humanity, but just for simplicity's sake, say it was twice the number alive today. So, fourteen billion people have had a chance to work on the question she'd asked, and the answer was still up for grabs. I took the night to think about it, and mull over a lifetime of theories. The next day I dealt with the usual distractions, and a couple rays of hope--the job problem may have a solution in reach; I'm sure that will affect the outcome of the story.

As a writer, I try to be consistent in tense. But I seem to have shifted from reflecting on things to writing them down as they happen. It will be the past, by the time you read it, but if I slip; well, now you know the cause.

I had a lot on my mind when I sat down to write, so it was not as easy to pick up the thread. In order for our conversation to resume, my avatar had to assert herself. But her question had been asked, and it was one I had thought about for almost as long as I'd lived. As I noted above, the question did not have a sure answer, though there were several popular opinions. I put those aside to consider as needed, but took my stance based on the clue she gave me.

Life is the box.

The physical universe might exist without life to observe it, but the absence of life is death--and death marks one boundary of reality. The origins of the physical universe also lay beyond a point we could not explore within the bounds of reality. Ironical, since experience shows us the example of before and after. As far as our personal lives were concerned, reality and other people were here before us, and unless we all died in an apocalypse, reality and other people would be here after us.

The irony being, we could apply our minds to possibilities beyond the scope of our direct experience, but in the pursuit of facts in support of some truth, we were forced to employ fabrications. Philosophy (sometimes in the guise of Theology) and Science (in particular, Physics) represent the two major paths we've taken, as a species, to describe Reality. But in general, experience--in the context of life--provides us with our conventional views of reality.

While the physical universe provides the foundation for life, in practical terms, it is life that provides the foundation for us to engage in reality. Our minds and--especially--dreams can provide us with experiences that rival reality, and technology comes closer every day to producing convincing virtual realities. In "The Matrix" reality depended entirely on the interpretation of perceptions of structured information--"just electrical impulses in the brain."

Physics and Philosophy have both proposed that the physical universe is an illusion, an infinitely complex structure of matter and energy ultimately derived from pure information. Decades of study and generations of observation and experimentation are required to consciously comprehend the logic or insights leading to that proposition. The mysteries of the mind and the universe have yet to be bridged in a conclusive way.

It was easy to get caught up in study and speculation, but I pulled my head out of that mud and took note of the key observation. I had already pointed out that the paradox of reality was that it presented itself to us as fact. The problem with defining reality through science or philosophy was that at some point we ran out of facts. It was a direct short cut to the wildest implications of philosophy and physics. The basis of reality was fact.

Reality was an interpretation of the facts.

At the point where our curiosity could not be satisfied by the obvious fact of reality--at the point where we ran out of facts--we started to create things, concepts and constructs, to continue our pursuit of fact. As soon as invention and imagination were applied we were undeniably participating in changing, possibly even creating reality. And that... that presents us with a couple of interesting facts.

A construct allowed a mind to probe the physical universe in search of facts. A concept allowed a mind to leverage itself into perceiving a different reality, a different understanding of the facts. A different understanding of the physical universe might change our assumptions about how a mind interacts with the physical universe.

I had to stop writing for a moment because the implication was staring me in the face.

A fact was a bit of information acquired through measurement; through perception. A perception was a mechanism; a means or method of obtaining facts. A perception could be inaccurate,

so a fact had an underlying truth. A truth was holographic. Every fact contained a piece of the truth. A fact always had a context. A fact alone was meaningless, without an interpretation; an analysis of its truth.

An interpretation required perspective and perspective required structure, but interpretation was meaningless without understanding. An understanding was impossible without awareness. Awareness was a completely subjective state of being. A completely subjective being can only exist in its own awareness. An awareness containing only itself was oblivious. All it could be aware of was itself. That in turn sparked self awareness; the nucleus of understanding.

A brain, its senses, and a stream of information could harness self-awareness, providing it with the structure and resources to become a conscious a mind. A mind, a structured awareness, could contain and comprehend information. An evolving mind would reinforce the evolution of a more evolved brain. A more evolved brain would have the potential to house a more intelligent and cognitive mind--a mind that could grasp the deeper implications of the information it processed.

Information was paradoxical. A discrete piece of information could have a vast scope of meanings and implications. Information was an abstraction, as elusive as a dream, and yet that same information can have structure and representation, a manifestation as solid and certain as our physical reality. The more information a mind had access to, the more information that mind could derive from a given fact. Information could be passive, but information could also carry intent.

I could have continued to follow this chain of revelations, but I was already moving past the point. Whatever else we wanted to think about the physical universe, the point was that it was expressed. It provided an environment, structure, resources, and opportunities with incredible value to life. It also provided an endless stream of information that only a conscious, perceptive, intelligent mind could hope to exploit.

Without saying anything, the universe sat there telling us everything we would possibly need to know to understand the most important thing of all. It says nothing; we give the message to ourselves. We blink in amazement and think, "I am..." ...and the rest is gravy. The rest is a choice. It's up to us to decide how to benefit from this opportunity. How we acknowledge it. How we share it. Ultimately, how we survive it.

We are designed to be selfish. We are designed to find ourselves. So we face an immediate challenge. Everything is there for us to take, so of course we started taking. We started by taking it for granted that we could. We're human, so we start out taking what we're given. As we grow and become more independent, we discover we can take what we want. Unfortunately, we're in this together, so inevitably someone else takes something we wanted.

We began to compete. All the world's problems started right there. Someone else was there first. Someone else got the best seat. Someone pushed once too often. Someone threw the first punch.

Someone had to stop the fighting. Someone had to make the rules. Someone had to keep the peace. Someone had to collect the money so someone could pay the bills. Someone decided the best solution was to take control, limiting other people's options.

Somewhere along the way, we created this reality. We all still have the same opportunity, but the challenge before us has grown harder. We made a mess we had cope with. We accepted the version of reality we've presented to ourselves, unaware that we built a wall between ourselves and the opportunity we were truly given. But, strangely, our mistakes and foolishness have borne unexpected fruit. We have truly realized our humanity.



"I imagine it's pretty hard for you to sit still, right now," she began, in a conspiratorially amused tone. The look on my face must have been eloquently agitated, because she met it and started laughing. When she recovered, she patted my head and said, "I can see that our chat has had an unintended consequence. A bit of drive by enlightenment."

"Not my fault. I may have been the one at the keyboard, but it seems that my sub-conscious has been driving. I've slipped into philosophical writing before, but that wasn't something I consciously set out to write. Were you expecting something like that when you asked the question?"

"Actually, I half expected you to dig up one of those old bits of philosophy. You have plenty of it on your blog and hard drive. I can't say I'm disappointed with what you did instead. It very nicely captures the key concepts we explored in author or goddess mode," she observed. "I definitely expected you to mention the thing about participation as requirement for reality. That has been a part of your philosophy for so long that it didn't occur to you to mention it."

I tilted my head to the side and then shrugged. "I sort of think of it as a given. I think I touched on it in passing, but you're right, I haven't explained it," I admitted. "I think it was something I picked up on as a kid, and suffered through all my life. Because I'm not the person people see and interact with--and especially because I had to pretend to be who they thought I was--my life's had a surreal quality.

"Because I wasn't fully participating, it never felt entirely real. A role-playing game could seem more real, both because I chose my role and because the other players recognized my participation. A book comes to life for me when the characters are interacting. Most of all, there's the contrast between dreams and reality. In dreams, things seem real and there are people I am interacting with, but I don't share those experiences with anyone in the waking world."

She nodded. "I think that is also a measure of reality, that things have consequence--and persistence. Dreams tend to lack in both. On the whole, however, the point I was shooting for is that

without other people involved, the difference between dreaming and waking would become largely meaningless."

I conceded the point with a slight nod.

"Of course, my purpose in bringing that up is to say that you value the existence of others," she proposed, waiting for my confirmation. I bobbed my head a few more times. She smothered a smile, glancing around for a place to perch, and deciding to stay in my head. "Well, then, you should understand the position I was in, when choosing how to confront you."

I pressed my lips together. I knew she would get back to that, but I was expecting to face it in the last chapter. "I'm not exactly guessing you'll say, 'If I had the power to confront you in the flesh, there would still be reasons not to.' And by that, you mean the people in my reality."

She held out her hand and turned her palm up, suddenly looking serious. "I have faith in you, and I'd love to end this fiction the way you--and probably your readers--wish. But this is not something to rush someone into. Writing this has allowed you to clear out a ton of mental blocks, and I'm happy for that. At the same time, you posted it thinking, 'The way my life is going, I'll be on the streets in a few weeks,' not expecting to last very long there.

"I can understand the temptation to say your piece, tack on a happy ending, and ride off into oblivion," she divulged, tapping into my darker thoughts. "I totally see how that conforms to reality. But I'm not going to let you do something that stupid, telling yourself you are powerless!"

My eyebrows crawled up my forehead, and I kind of laughed under my breath, "I honestly don't know how this ends. Not the story. Not the dream. Certainly not my life. I'm stretched so tight I should just snap. I put myself in a position I can't back out of. But I think I see where you're going. I don't want to compromise myself any more. I think you're trying to tell me I don't want to compromise the world either," I concluded.

She gave me a sad look and then sighed. "You have always had that block," she told me, tiredly. "You have the mind to defy reality, and grasp the responsibility of power, to openly admit you need to have this power, use this power, in order to feel like a normal human being. I think I could even get you to admit that you want this power--that it's a part of you that needs to be expressed.

"I just don't know if you can allow yourself to accept this power as your birthright," she charged, leveling an irritated look at me. "You would be blown away for a moment, but you would find your stride. You've been practicing for this for decades. I've told you before, I can't pour water into a full glass. I cannot give you what you already have. I am not saying, 'No.'"

She pulled me into an imaginary scene just to get in my face and poke me in the chest, for final emphasis, adding, "You are!"



That was a pretty blunt way for her to confront me with the problem I had created for myself. But I have to admit, it sort of worked. It certainly got me to see it. It had been at the edge of my vision, or right in the middle of my blind spot. I originally set out to find a way to put my real self into reality as I knew it. Unfortunately, in order to do that, I would have to change it. Even spelled out, that somehow misses the point.

She got it, because she understood the underlying premise. It is an abuse of power to change other people to suit yourself. I could say that I worried about the consequences of opening a door that led others to claim power. The truth is that the only way they could claim that power was to find it in themselves. They'd claim it by becoming true to themselves, because that's where the power comes from.

The process required a lot of honesty, and the ability to understand your instincts and listen to your intuition. The most difficult part of having power was allowing yourself to use it. I knew that much from experience. It's frustrating to say, but I had way too much experience denying myself. I wanted to believe her argument would cause something to shift and open up the flood gates. I could imagine myself sitting there suddenly transformed in revelation.

I could even, almost, believe it.

The almost is worth looking at, because it is not rooted in doubt. I can easily picture it happening, and I know that I am not allowing it to happen. In part because I can't imagine what would come next. As the Oracle said, "We can't see past a choice we don't understand." I feel like I know why I am saying no, but that's really a rationalization. I'm not telling myself, "Absolutely, not." For the most part it seems to be, "Not yet."

Cue mental screaming, because I have no idea what I am waiting for, but it's agonizingly frustrating.

I can say this, at the moment, though. I know exactly what I want to do, and for practical reasons there are a few things I need to do, but there is one thing I don't want to do, because I respect the reality of others. Crap. "I don't want to change reality," I groaned, instantly miserable. I put a hand to my forehead, covering my eyes, and stopped, because I felt a mental block clear.

"Who said you needed to?" she asked as I removed my hand and looked her in the face. I'd been just about to say the same thing.

"Can't pour water into a full glass," I murmured under my breath. She kept saying that to me, and though she was referring to information or power I already had, it came close to saying what I needed to hear. "I understood myself as being powerless in this perspective," I realized. Repetitive though it was, I continued, "I could not find a way to express myself in reality," adding, "in the context of my understanding of reality."

I shut my mouth and raced through the implications. I had spent a thousand nights trying to will my body to change; imagining it in detail. One a few of those nights, I thought I'd succeeded for a few brief moments. I never managed to disprove the assumption that I had no power over reality. Discouraged, but not deterred, I continued to challenge that assumption, and over time profoundly altered my perspective of reality.

I'd moved out of line with the conventional understanding of reality. I found a different way of looking at the problem that I could not test because, however excluded I felt, I still respected other people's reality. I understood that their perspective--their understanding of reality--was crucial to their understanding of themselves. They were, for reasons as different as they were each unique, struggling with the same frustration with reality.

Just as I had, the human race had used its imagination to challenge that assumption--developing the concepts and constructs needed to free their minds. (I had to learn them somewhere.) Some of those concepts have been around for thousands of years, and some we could never have imagined without first inventing science, and technology, to test the solidity of the universe and confront the limits of perception. People were cultivating a new understanding in fact, fiction, fantasy and philosophy.

People were primed for a new understanding of the mind. It just waited to be realized. For now, it was just all just a dream.

Chapter 9

I felt like I'd reached a climax of sorts, as I considered that observation. If I'd been able to dive directly into writing the last chapter--this chapter--I might have been able to capture the thought that would unlock the whole thing. Instead, reality chose that moment to change on me. I started this story thinking I'd run out of time, after three years and five months of fruitless job searching. I'd spent my last dime, I was behind on my rent--and I was more than fifty-thousand dollars in debt.

I expected to be out on the streets at the end of the month. I'd even come to terms with it. It made it easy to admit to things I'd become wary of putting down in writing. In the course of the last five months, I'd faced an unpleasant realization. I'd qualified myself for a job that would pay very well, but would contribute nothing else to the realization of my dreams. I knew that it was a sacrifice I'd be willing to make--just to pay off my debts--but honestly, money was the least of my problems.

I wrapped up chapter eight and went to bed, and in the morning--before I settled in to write--I got an email about a design project. I'll spare you the details, and just say that it was a small project that would keep me going for another month or two. After setting up an interview date, I got another surprise. A phone call from a recruiter concerning a position I'd applied for. I was being offered the job, and I was happy to accept it. It would keep me employed through the middle of summer, and I might earn enough to survive another long period of job hunting.

I spent those next three days working on securing both jobs. I determined I could complete the requirements of the design job in the hours I was not tied up with my day job, and the client was willing to accept that. I spent a day and a half on the paperwork required for contract employment for that day

job, and received my official start date. I spent the other half of that third day writing a quote for the design project.

It was early evening before I was free to return my attention to the story. It was not the first time my writing was interrupted by the needs of making a living. It was not even the first time reality had presented me with a sudden bend in the road of life that I had not seen coming. It was a far cry from the kind of change I needed, in order to be true to myself. Quite the opposite, in fact, since I'd be forced to crawl back into the role of the man I appeared to be, in order to do those jobs.

Anything less would interfere with my work, and I needed to be making money. If I was careful with what I earned, I might even be able to focus on writing the first book of my avatar's epic once I had free time to write. I could no longer be blind to the fact that, if reality could not accommodate my dream--to be me in the flesh--the story became my best reason to live. The prison of my life might be the price of my dreams.

That life was what prompted my dream.

I summed up my thoughts and opened my mind to see if any of my personas had anything to add. Sometimes they're just waiting for the chance to speak, when they know I'm ready to listen. It's a process that can be difficult to describe. I'm really just trying to get out of my own way, to give myself the benefit of a different, sometimes better, perspective. I could feel the masculine part of myself preparing to take on the weight of responsibility of getting me through those jobs.

I could sort of feel his eyes on me, the weight of his hand on my shoulder a silent promise that however hard a path it might be, he'd be there to help me through it. Nothing more needed to be said on that, but he'd respond if another me needed to talk to him about paying the price of dreams. His subtle presence allowed me to be myself right then, a different girl from the one I become in the context of the story. Like the story, that girl has a reality of her own; I support it but I only experience it vicariously.

"I might as well just jump in, before you wander off track," she spoke up, imagining herself at the eye of the hurricane that is my thoughts. "I wanted to address a couple of things in response to what's happening to your reality. I agree that it makes it possible for you to write my story; you weren't in a position to do anything like that when you started on this part of it. The timing is curious, but it could not have happened if you had not actively pursued the opportunity," she pointed out.

"I think I know where you're going with this," I told her.

She smiled with a slight roll and shake of her head. "I just want to point out that it shows how a change in reality is possible without the dramatic use of power. It's mostly a matter of applying yourself in a way that is appropriate for the intended outcome. The more particular you are about what you

achieve, the more you have to apply yourself to creating the opportunity to achieve it. Under the present circumstances of reality, it's hard for anyone to get a good, paying job.

"It's rare that it's also the job you wanted--a perfect job is virtually impossible to get--but no one sane will refuse an opportunity that provides them with something they need," she argued, and I saw no reason to object. It was the same argument that kept me from rejecting reality. I get most of what a person needs out of life. I just don't get to be me. I may never get what I want out of life, but it has given me countless things I needed.

The heart of my problem in life is a question I can only answer one way. Do I need to be me?

I do. No one else could be.

I have to be present in any expression of myself, even if the expression contradicts me. In my understanding of myself, it is not sufficient to be the product of my circumstances. I am more than the sum of my parts; I am literally something in spite of them. I could not escape my suffering by embracing the definition of me provided by my circumstances. Trying, I only compounded it. So, life confronted me with another need.

The need for the means to express myself. The need to do the impossible.

"I can feel your thoughts racing ahead, but I think it's easier for people to understand the desire to find the perfect job," she interrupted my musing, sticking to her topic. "A perfect job is nothing more than an occupation that is appropriate for who you are. One that you can engage in fully, and which allows you to realize your full potential. It's what everyone needs, and it seems impossible for everyone to have."

"I wonder if there's ever been a person who truly had it," I told her. "I don't know if people can distinguish between the job they want and the job that is perfect for them. I think we tend to limit ourselves to the jobs that one could reasonably expect to have and call the best of those the perfect job to have. The perfect job is impossible to have, because we don't even consider the job possible."

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"A job is something that needs to be done," she pointed out, "even if there's no profit for the one who must do it. Payment is just one incentive to work. Survival is another. Protecting and preserving something you love is an incentive great enough for people to give their lives in order to get something done. One way to identify the perfect job is to understand that it's a job that could never be done if you did not choose to do it.

"My story is one that only you can write; even though I'm better qualified to write it, I am technically just part of you. My story is really just a consequence of the job you've done trying to realize

your own potential," she told me, bringing us back on track. "Writing it has its own benefits, not least is the money you might make if you publish it. There is still a lot of work to do if you're ever to realize your dream. The story came about as part of the work you've done, and sharing it is one way that work can help support you."

"I suppose that's true, assuming there's an audience willing to pay to read it," I noted. "I should be honest, though, writing it is going to be a lot of work; made harder by the circumstances I'm likely to be in while I write it."

"Perhaps, but consider what you could gain in the process of finally writing it," she argued. "Consider all the things you confronted just in these nine chapters. The theories a larger work would allow you to present to those readers. The story was in many ways just a test of those theories; a massive thought experiment. It would help you just as much to reconsider them."

"There are things you know, that you don't allow yourself to know in your daily persona. Every insight drives you to act on your deeper understanding. You won't because you're so conscious of the consequences of using power in a place where no one else has used it." She throttled back on her intensity and gave me a look of entreaty. "The story even addresses the consequence of shattering people's grasp of reality," she reminded me.

That had been a cataclysm caused by the use of magic to wage war; by too many people attempting to turn reality against each other. It opened the door to the shattered realms, the remnants of other compromised realities. A flaw the naked goddess exploited to embody herself as my avatar. "It was what made it possible for people to accept being confronted with a child of paradox," I responded, referring to her arrival in the past.

"On the Eve of Paradox, people were forced to call on powers they'd never prepared themselves for to survive the assault of someone else's power," she elaborated. "the impact opened a rift in time and space that could only be bridged by the mind. Those of us who could cope with paradox were drawn to that battle, and we patched the holes torn in our reality as well as we could with the fragments of other realms that lost their integrity."

"I fell in when I was seventeen, and I stumbled out of the Eye of Paradox three years before I was born," she said, knowing full well I already knew it. "In a way, I became the herald of that apocalypse; unable to do a thing to prevent it, I did what I could to ensure the world would survive it. It was ten years of war and I took three trips through it."

I sighed. "I saw that option; I couldn't quite sort out the paradoxes, but I could almost work it out in twenty years with only two loops through it."

She gave me a look of concern and annoyance. "I know. I've been here for at least five years and studied your notes. I know you can see my story, but you let yourself get in the way of truly knowing it. I'd hoped that meant your life here was the nightmare I endured for an eternal moment when my demon possessed me," she confessed. "If there is any context for your life in the terms of my story, it's the idea you explored--the one you've resisted employing."

I did not need an explanation. Over the past few years, I'd worked on an idea that was elegant in principle but in practice seemed insane. It was a concept that presented me with a starting point in the paradox, and a life as a random boy--either in the story or out here in reality. "Chance conception makes more sense than the outcome of a confrontation between the dragon and the demon. Especially since the latter implies that your demon is loose in this reality." I almost growled.

She shrugged, responding with admirable sarcasm, "Well, let's not dare to make any assumptions about what's really going on out here in this reality."

I sighed, "Look, I know there's room for doubt in my childhood. I never really knew my father, though I know he didn't take responsibility for me or his marriage, leaving my mother with little choice but to put me up for adoption. Did he fail as a father? Yes. Was that because he was possessed by a demon? I can't rule out the possibility, but I wouldn't give it a high probability."

"But it makes sense, in terms of the story," she argued, playing devil's advocate, "for the dragon to put my soul out in the open; to move me out of its blind spot. It's certainly something he would have considered doing. Something he's implied he might have done on instinct." I knew the scenario. I'd worked on it for a few years. I tended toward keeping the scope of the story within the limits of my imagination, and focused on the second option.

"The dragon could have just as easily fathered a male incarnation of me in your world," I objected. "I've seen signs of him in your story from the very beginning. Admittedly, I'm not happy to think there's another part of me going through the same hell I have. But, at least in your world he would be able to do something about it. His life is one where I would have access to the means to express myself physically."

She took a deep breath and released it in a long sigh. "I am afraid you're right. I had a life where I was the son of the dragon and a student of magic. I went through all the same soul searching you did, and used my magic to redefine myself. I started to remember that life, watching it come to an end, then walking away from the ashes with an ember of hope and a terrible doubt. I didn't know enough to understand the whole story until I tried to explain to the dragon how I got myself pregnant."

I laughed, "If that doesn't get people begging me to tell the whole story, I can't imagine what else would." Then I sobered. "You know, if you add his life to yours, you get my current age, give or take a few months. Not counting the time you've overlapped me," I observed in bit of a daze.

I considered the ramifications of what she told me while my body stepped out for a cigarette. I guess technically I was on autopilot, but my mind was occupied with the revelation of the correct path through her paradox. I returned to the conversation determined to finish our conversation without divulging the solution. After all, it looked like I was setting myself up to really start writing the story.

"I can see that this means that the darkest parts of the story really do fit in," I told her. "I can see now why you were hoping I could help you get home. I mean, I can see the path leading you to me, but I don't see a loose thread remaining that indicates your return."

"I know. I've come to terms with the fact that I am you; that my life was a way for you to explore the possibility of becoming a better incarnation of yourself," she confided. "I'd hoped I'd discover that you fall into the loop, become the boy I just mentioned, who in turn became me. That would leave me here in your place. I just don't know if I would notice."

"Maybe we switched places a long time ago, and I just got caught up in the memory of who I was, before I found a way out," she speculated, in a subdued awe.

"Well, it sort of became a habit for me to adapt to my circumstances," I laughed, shaking my head in wonder. "When I wake up from dreams, the most disconcerting part is feeling my mind slipping back in tune with reality."



Ending a story can be a tricky thing. What I was writing was both a prologue and epilogue for an unwritten story, so it was even trickier. There is no way to prove a story has its own reality. It does not challenge the reality we live in to say I could return to myself after escaping my daily life by pursuing my dreams in fiction. It was ironic that the combined age of the two characters I became was roughly equal to my own age. I would not have planned that.

Assuming I get to write the entire epic, I'll be much older when it's done, but that'll just be recapitulation. It took me as long to comprehend the story as it would have taken to live it. So, the story is a work of fiction with an odd sort of truth. I created the world it was set in, but the characters my protagonist encountered made the world their own. Her life allowed me to explore questions and options I did not have in my own. As part of me, she gives me a new perspective on things.

"I can certainly say this," she interrupted, to share her opinion, "your world isn't ready for me. It's barely ready for you to share our odd little dream. This glimpse you've offered is a bit like a dream. It jumps through something bigger and leaves you wondering what you've actually seen. So, some may just write you off as being crazy."

"That's okay," I assured her. "I do have a knack for crazy. I'm an artist, so it's to be expected, I guess. It's ultimately up to the reader to decide what to make of the story. That can never happen if I leave it unwritten. It's more important that they be able to relate to you, and what you experienced in the context of the story. Me being completely transparent about the creative processes that went into creating the story does not diminish its worth as a story."

"And what about your dream?" she asked.

"You mean, finding a way to fit the real me into reality?" I clarified. She nodded. "We'll just have to see. The story addresses how my problem was solved using magic. There is even a point where the same type of problem was addressed using a more advanced technology." I shrugged, "I already know that anything is possible in the mind. The question that really needs to be asked is: How is anything possible outside of it?"

"Um... that's not a rhetorical question, is it?" she frowned.

"It's a legitimate question," I assured her. "I can't give up at impossible. I have to learn the right questions to ask. Then I have to answer them."